

Aquifer Open Study Notes

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This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

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Luke 1:1

Many people have set out to write accounts: Luke was not the first to put the history of Jesus into written form. Most scholars believe that Luke used Mark's Gospel and other written and oral sources in his writing. • fulfilled: This word can simply mean "accomplished," but Luke is thinking of Jesus' fulfillment of Old Testament promises ([4:21](#); [24:44](#)).

Luke 1:1-4

Luke begins his Gospel with a formal preface in the style of the best Greek writers of his day. These four verses are some of the finest literary Greek in the New Testament.

Luke 1:3

As a good historian, Luke carefully investigated everything in the history of Jesus from the beginning in order to present a reliable historical account. • an accurate account: Some versions translate this phrase "in consecutive order," but it refers to an orderly or carefully written account, not to chronological sequence. • The name Theophilus means "loved by God" or "one who loves God"; it is probably a personal name, not a descriptive name. Different theories identify him as (1) an influential unbeliever, (2) a new convert needing instruction, (3) the judge overseeing Paul's trial (the book of Acts ends with Paul imprisoned in Rome, awaiting trial), or (4) the patron who sponsored Luke's writing project. The last possibility is the most likely, as it was common to dedicate a literary work to a financial patron and the Greek word translated most honorable indicates someone of high social status.

Luke 1:5

Herod was king of Judea: See "Herod the Great" Profile. • a Jewish priest named Zechariah: The priests were descendants of Aaron, Moses' brother ([Exod 28:1](#)). • the priestly order of Abijah: See

study note on Luke 1:8-9; see also [1 Chr 24:10](#). • Elizabeth was also from the priestly line of Aaron: It was considered especially pious for a priest to marry a woman from a priestly family.

Luke 1:5-2:52

Luke's first two chapters give an account of Jesus' birth and introduce key themes that will appear later in Luke-Acts. The announcements and birth stories for Jesus and John the Baptist run side by side, showing their parallel roles in bringing God's salvation. At each point, Jesus is shown to be greater. John is the forerunner announcing Jesus' coming; Jesus is the Savior.

Luke 1:7

Elizabeth was unable to conceive: Childbearing was viewed as the highest calling for a woman, and infertility brought social stigma and shame. God miraculously intervened in the lives of various Old Testament women so they could bear children ([Gen 18:10-12](#); [25:21](#); [30:22-23](#); [Judg 13](#); [1 Sam 1:1-28](#)).

Luke 1:8-9

his order was on duty that week . . . he was chosen by lot: It was common in Old Testament times to cast lots (similar to throwing dice) to determine God's will ([1 Chr 26:13-16](#); [Neh 11:1](#); [Prov 16:33](#); [Jon 1:7](#)). There were twenty-four orders of priests ([1 Chr 24:1-19](#)) that took turns in the Temple, and lots were cast to determine which priest would serve in the sanctuary. There were a large number of priests, so this privilege might come only once in a priest's lifetime. The angel appeared at the most sacred moment of Zechariah's life. • to enter the sanctuary of the Lord and burn incense: Luke uses the word here translated sanctuary (Greek naos) for the Temple building, not the whole Temple grounds, which he calls hieron ([Luke 2:27](#)). The Temple building included the Holy Place and the Most Holy Place (see [Heb 9:1-5](#)). The priests burned incense twice a day in the Holy Place.

Luke 1:12-13

Zechariah was shaken and overwhelmed with fear: Fear and awe are common reactions when someone sees an angel or experiences the presence of God ([Judg 6:22-23](#); [13:22](#); [Isa 6:5](#)). The person is often reassured by a saying such as Don't be afraid.

- you are to name him John: John means "the Lord has shown favor." This favor came to Elizabeth and Zechariah through their son and to the Israelite nation through the Messiah, whose coming John would announce.

Luke 1:15

He must never touch wine or other alcoholic drinks: In the Old Testament, abstaining from alcohol was part of the Nazirite vow of special dedication to God (see [Num 6:1-21](#)). This vow was usually temporary (see [Acts 18:18](#); [21:23, 26](#)); for some individuals such as Samson ([Judg 13:4-7](#)), Samuel (cp. [1 Sam 1:11](#)), and John the Baptist, it was a lifelong commitment.

- filled with the Holy Spirit, even before his birth: See [Luke 1:41, 44](#).

Luke 1:17

He will be a man with the spirit and power of Elijah: The prophet Malachi predicted that God would send Elijah before the time of God's salvation (see [Mal 3:1](#); [4:5-6](#)). John fulfilled this role by preparing the way for the Lord's coming.

Luke 1:19

I am Gabriel! Two angels are named in Scripture: Gabriel ([Dan 8:16](#); [9:21](#)) and Michael ([Dan 10:13](#); [12:1](#); [Jude 1:9](#); [Rev 12:7](#)).

Luke 1:20

now . . . you will be silent and unable to speak: This discipline for Zechariah's lack of faith was also a sign that confirmed the prophecy. The Greek word translated *silent* in [1:22](#) can also mean "deaf" ([7:22](#); cp. [1:62](#)).

- Zechariah is contrasted with Mary, who responded with faith ([1:38](#)).

Luke 1:24

went into seclusion for five months: The reason for this seclusion is unknown and does not seem related to any Old Testament custom or command. Perhaps it was a spiritual retreat to honor God for answered prayer.

Luke 1:26

Nazareth, a village in Galilee, was an insignificant, disreputable little village southwest of the Sea of Galilee (see [John 1:46](#)).

Luke 1:27

engaged to be married: In Jewish culture, marriages were arranged, and engagement was a formal legal contract between two families. Girls were normally married by their mid-teens.

- Joseph, a descendant of King David: See [Matt 1:1-16](#). Joseph's ancestry is significant because the Messiah was to be a descendant of King David ([2 Sam 7:11-16](#); [Isa 9:7](#)).

Luke 1:31

you will name him Jesus: Jesus means "the Lord saves."

Luke 1:32-33

These verses echo God's covenant with David ([2 Sam 7:11-16](#)), the foundational promise of the coming Messiah (see also [Isa 9:6-7](#); [11:1-5](#); [Jer 23:5-6](#); [33:15-16](#); [Ezek 37:24-25](#)).

Luke 1:35

The Holy Spirit will come upon you: Jesus' conception was miraculous, by the power of the Most High. No further detail is provided as to how this happened.

Luke 1:36

your relative Elizabeth: The King James Version identifies Elizabeth as Mary's cousin, but the Greek term is more general.

Luke 1:39

The hill country of Judea was 80–100 miles away from Nazareth, at least a four-day journey.

Luke 1:41

Elizabeth's child leaped within her: See [1:15](#). John was already announcing the Messiah's coming. • Elizabeth was filled with the Holy Spirit: In the Old Testament, being filled with the Spirit was often associated with a prophetic gift. The Spirit of prophecy was again appearing in Israel (see [1:67](#); [2:25](#), [27](#)).

Luke 1:46–55

Mary's song is the first of three songs of praise in the birth narrative. It is called the *Magnificat* ("magnifies"), from the first word in the Latin translation. The song has many parallels to Hannah's prayer in [1 Sam 2:1–10](#). The fact that God cares for the oppressed and reverses their fortunes is a common theme throughout Luke's Gospel. The coming of God's Kingdom brings salvation to rejected and outcast people.

Luke 1:48

all generations will call me blessed: In Middle Eastern culture, honor and shame were extremely important, and one's legacy to future generations was highly cherished.

Luke 1:51

His mighty arm personifies God's mighty power (see [Ps 98:1](#); [Isa 40:10](#)).

Luke 1:54–55

Gabriel's words in [1:32–33](#) recalled God's covenant with David; here Mary alluded to God's covenant with Abraham ([Gen 12:1–3](#); [17:3–8](#)). • The coming of Jesus brought glory to Israel and salvation to the Gentiles (see [Luke 2:32](#)).

Luke 1:59

God commanded every Israelite male to be circumcised when eight days old ([Gen 17:9–14](#); [Lev 12:3](#)). Circumcision signified the child's incorporation into the covenant community of Israel. • They wanted to name him Zechariah: It was common to name a child after a relative. The family and friends were surprised because John was not the name of any of his relatives.

Luke 1:62–63

they used gestures: Zechariah was mute and deaf (see study note on 1:20). Zechariah's obedience in naming the child John confirmed his faith, and his voice and hearing were restored.

Luke 1:66

the hand of the Lord: This *anthropomorphism* (describing God with human characteristics, cp. [1:51](#)) meant that God was at work in John's life.

Luke 1:67–79

This second hymn of the birth narrative is called the *Benedictus* ("Blessed" or "Praise"), from the first word of the Latin translation. The hymn expects God's Messiah to deliver the Israelites from their enemies. Salvation entails physical deliverance and forgiveness of sins ([1:77](#)).

Luke 1:68

he has visited and redeemed his people: This recalls the exodus from Egypt, when God rescued his people from Pharaoh ([Exod 3:7–10](#), [17–20](#)).

Luke 1:69

He has sent us a mighty Savior (literally *has raised up a horn of salvation for us*): A “horn of salvation” was the horn of a powerful animal such as a ram or an ox. To “raise up a horn” implies strength and power (see also [Pss 89:24; 132:17](#)). • from the royal line of his servant David: See study note on Luke 1:32–33.

Luke 1:71

saved from our enemies: The people of Israel hoped for rescue from their physical enemies, the Romans; Jesus brought salvation from sin, Satan, and death.

Luke 1:76–77

And you, my little son: Zechariah turned from speaking about the coming Messiah to address his newborn son, John, who would prepare the Messiah’s way. • called the prophet of the Most High: John was the last and greatest in the line of Old Testament prophets (see [7:28](#)). • prepare the way for the Lord: See [Isa 40:3](#).

Luke 1:78

the morning light from heaven is about to break upon us: The Messiah is identified in the Old Testament as a light shining in darkness ([Isa 9:2; 42:6–7; 49:6; Mal 4:2](#)).

Luke 1:80

John grew up and became strong in spirit: Cp. [2:40, 52; 1 Sam 2:21, 26; 3:19](#). • John probably lived in the wilderness west of the Jordan River and southeast of Jerusalem. It was a place of testing ([Deut 8:2; Pss 78, 95, 107](#)) as well as spiritual retreat and preparation ([Exod 3; 1 Kgs 19:4–6, 11–18; Isa 40:3](#)).

Luke 2:1

Caesar Augustus, whose given name was Octavian, ruled the Roman Empire from 27 BC to AD 14. Prior to his time, Rome was a republic ruled by a senate.

The Roman senate gave Augustus supreme authority as emperor, and the republic became an empire. Augustus secured the empire’s borders and established the *Pax Romana* (“Roman Peace”), a period of unprecedented stability and prosperity in the Mediterranean world. • A census registered the people for tax purposes.

Luke 2:1–7

Having described John’s birth, Luke gives a parallel account of Jesus’ birth, with emphasis on its lowliness. Although he was the glorious Messiah, Jesus entered the world in humble circumstances.

Luke 2:2

Quirinius was governor of Syria: Quirinius held this post AD 6–9. In 6–4 BC, Quirinius also had authority over Judea, possibly through some kind of joint rule. He may have begun the census. Historical accounts mention three other censuses at that time (in Syria, Gaul, and Spain), and there was no reason not to have one in Judea, though it is not mentioned in secular records. Jesus was born around 6–4 BC, before Herod the Great died in 4 BC (see [Matt 2:1–19](#)).

Luke 2:3–4

Since Joseph was a descendant of King David, he returned to David’s hometown of Bethlehem ([1 Sam 17:12, 58; 20:6](#)), a tiny village in Judea five miles south of Jerusalem, where [Mic 5:2](#) predicted that the Messiah would be born.

Luke 2:5

Mary, to whom he was engaged: See study note on 1:27.

Luke 2:7

wrapped him snugly in strips of cloth: This common practice showed motherly love and care (see [Ezek 16:4](#)). • A manger was a feeding trough for animals. • no lodging available for them: This is a more accurate translation than the traditional “no room in the inn.” The word translated *lodging* does

not mean an inn (there were no inns in tiny Bethlehem), but either a guest room in a private house or a public shelter for travelers. Since there was no normal lodging, Joseph and Mary moved to an area reserved for animals.

Luke 2:8

Shepherds were sometimes portrayed in Judaism as drifters and dishonest troublemakers. This stereotype was not universal, however; in the Old Testament, shepherds are usually viewed positively (e.g., [Ps 23:1](#)). Jesus came to common people such as these poor and humble peasants. • staying in the fields: This suggests warmer months of the year, perhaps March through November, though some shepherds stayed out year-round. The actual month of Jesus' birth is unknown. • They were guarding their flocks against thieves and wild animals.

Luke 2:9–10

terrified: As with Zechariah and Mary, the angelic presence was glorious and frightening. The angel told the shepherds, "Don't be afraid" (cp. [1:11–13, 28–30](#)). • I bring you good news: This verb (Greek *euangelizō*, "I evangelize") is from the same root as the word for "Good News" (Greek *euangelion*, sometimes translated *gospel*; e.g., [Gal 2:5, 7, 14](#)). Isaiah's prophecies describe God's salvation as good news (see, e.g., [Isa 52:7; 61:1](#)). • to all people (literally *to all the people*): In Luke's writings, "the people" (grammatical singular) always refers to the people of Israel. The shepherds were being told that Israel's salvation had arrived. It would ultimately go to all nations.

Luke 2:11

The word "Messiah" means "Anointed One." It comes from the Hebrew word *mashiakh* and is translated into Greek as *Christos*. The Messiah refers to the promised savior who would come from King David's family line (see study note on 1:32–33). As the apostles started preaching the good news about Jesus to the non-Jewish world, Christians started using *Christos* more as a name than a title.

Luke 2:12

this sign: Shepherds would appreciate the paradox and incongruity between the security of strips of cloth and the lowly circumstances of lying in a manger. Seeing a baby in such a setting was very unusual—a fitting sign that God was at work.

Luke 2:13

The armies of heaven reveal God's sovereign power and authority ([2 Kgs 6:17; Ps 148:2](#)). "Lord of Heaven's Armies" is a common Old Testament name for God (e.g., [1 Sam 1:11; 17:45; 2 Sam 7:8; Isa 5:16; Rom 9:29; Jas 5:4](#)).

Luke 2:14

Glory to God in highest heaven: This short hymn is known as the *Gloria in excelsis Deo* from the first line of the Latin translation. The Messiah's coming brings glory to God in the heavens and peace to humans on earth. • peace on earth to those with whom God is pleased: Peace indicates total well-being, not just the absence of hostility. The traditional translation, "on earth peace, good will toward men" (KJV), is based on the reading of some late manuscripts. The NLT text follows more reliable early manuscripts. Peace comes to the recipients of God's grace.

Luke 2:19

Mary kept all these things in her heart: Perhaps Mary reflected on the significance of these events and wondered about Jesus' destiny. It is also possible that Luke says this because Mary was his source of information on these events.

Luke 2:20

Glorifying and praising God are major themes throughout Luke's Gospel (e.g., [1:64; 2:13, 28; 5:25–26; 7:16; 13:13; 17:15, 18; 18:43; 19:37; 23:47; 24:53](#)).

Luke 2:21

Eight days later . . . circumcised: See study note on 1:59.

Luke 2:22

time for their purification offering: The law of Moses prescribed a forty-day period of ritual purification for women following childbirth ([Lev 12](#)), after which an offering was made ([Luke 2:24](#)).
 • to present him to the Lord: Every firstborn, whether human or animal, was to be offered to the Lord; humans were bought back with a redemption price (see [Exod 13:1-2, 15](#); [34:19-20](#); [Num 3:11-13](#); [18:15-16](#); [Neh 10:35-36](#)).

Luke 2:24

a pair of turtledoves or two young pigeons: This quote from [Lev 12:8](#) pertains to the purification ceremony after childbirth; Joseph and Mary offered the sacrifice prescribed for the poor.

Luke 2:25

Simeon was righteous and devout, like Zechariah and Elizabeth ([1:6](#)). They represent the righteous remnant of Israel that awaited God's salvation ([Isa 10:20-22](#)). Some have assumed that Simeon was a priest; the text says only that he was a devout man in Jerusalem. • eagerly waiting for the Messiah to come and rescue Israel (literally *awaiting Israel's consolation*): This is an allusion to [Isa 40:1](#), which promised comfort to Israel after returning from exile. • The Holy Spirit was upon him: See study note on Luke 1:41.

Luke 2:26

the Lord's Messiah (or *the Lord's Anointed*): This title, often used of David, came to refer to the Messiah, who would come from David's line.

Luke 2:27

to the Temple: This was the Temple compound, not the sanctuary. See study note on 1:8-9.

Luke 2:29-32

This third great hymn of the birth narrative is called the *Nunc dimittis* ("now dismiss"), from the first words of the Latin translation. The hymn praises God for allowing Simeon to see God's salvation.

Luke 2:30

I have seen your salvation: The phrase echoes [Isa 52:12](#).

Luke 2:31

The grammatical plural of people means all people, Jews and Gentiles (cp. study note on 2:9-10).

Luke 2:32

The prophet Isaiah predicted that the coming Kingdom of God would bring salvation to all the nations ([Isa 42:6-7](#); [49:6](#)). • the glory of your people Israel! This quote from [Isa 46:13](#) says that God's salvation will bring glory to Israel. Israel's role in the Old Testament was to bring glory to God by revealing God's light to the nations.

Luke 2:34

to cause many in Israel to fall: Many Israelites rejected Jesus as the Messiah (see [Isa 8:14-15](#)). • a sign from God: See [Luke 11:29-30](#); cp. [Isa 8:18](#).

Luke 2:35

the deepest thoughts of many hearts: Israel's true heart—whether for God or against him—would be revealed through their response to Jesus. • a sword will pierce your very soul: Mary would experience great pain at seeing her son rejected and dying on the cross.

Luke 2:36-38

Anna is the Greek equivalent of the Hebrew name Hannah, Samuel's mother ([1 Sam 1-2](#)). Jewish tradition identified seven Old Testament women as prophets: Sarah, Miriam, Deborah, Hannah, Abigail, Huldah, and Esther. Anna was another prophetic witness to Jesus' identity as the Messiah. • The tribe of Asher, one of the ten northern tribes of Israel, was named after Jacob's eighth son ([Gen 30:12-13](#)). Most of those who returned from Babylonian exile were from the tribe of Judah; other Israelites also knew their tribal ancestry in Jesus' day. For instance, the apostle Paul was from the tribe of Benjamin ([Phil 3:5](#)).

Luke 2:37

she lived as a widow to the age of eighty-four: In the ancient world, great age was associated with wisdom and honor. • She never left the Temple: This is probably hyperbole; we might say, "She was there all the time," reflecting her total dedication to God.

Luke 2:40

filled with wisdom, and God's favor was on him (cp. [1:80](#); [2:52](#)): The twin statements about Jesus' wisdom ([2:40](#), [52](#)) frame the story about Jesus' extraordinary wisdom at an early age.

Luke 2:41

Every year . . . the Passover festival: Passover, celebrating Israel's deliverance from slavery in Egypt, was one of three great annual festivals that Jewish men were expected to attend ([Exod 23:14-17](#); [Deut 16:16](#)). Jesus' family was devout and observant.

Luke 2:41-51

Jesus' visit to Jerusalem when he was twelve is the only account from Jesus' childhood recorded in the Gospels. Its main theme is Jesus' early spiritual insight, including his growing awareness both of his unique father-son relationship with God and of his unique mission.

Luke 2:42

Jesus was twelve years old: A Jewish boy entered into his covenant responsibilities at age thirteen (the *bar mitzvah* ceremony developed later to express this custom). With this visit, Jesus' parents were preparing him to fulfill his role in the covenant community.

Luke 2:44

they assumed he was among the other travelers: Joseph and Mary were probably traveling with a large caravan of relatives and friends from Galilee. Jesus probably spent a lot of time with his friends and relatives, so his parents were not worried at first.

Luke 2:46

The three days probably included one day traveling from Jerusalem, one day traveling back, and one day searching. • in the Temple: He was in the Temple compound, not the sanctuary. • listening to them and asking questions: Jesus was in the role of a student. In rabbinic instruction, a teacher responded to a student's question with a series of counter-questions. Jesus' insightful questions and answers amazed the teachers.

Luke 2:47

amazed at his understanding and his answers: Jesus fulfilled [Isa 11:2](#).

Luke 2:49

Didn't you know that I must be in my Father's house? Jesus was aware that his greatest loyalty belonged to his Father in heaven.

Luke 2:51

Although Jesus recognized his relationship to his heavenly Father, he was obedient to his earthly parents.

Luke 3:1

the fifteenth year of the reign of Tiberius: Tiberius Caesar became co-emperor with his stepfather Caesar Augustus in AD 11 and full emperor in AD 14, reigning until AD 37. Depending on which date Luke is referring to, John's public ministry began around AD 26/27 or AD 29/30; Jesus began his own ministry shortly thereafter. • Pilate: Pontius Pilate was governor of Judea from AD 26–36 (see "Pontius Pilate" Profile). • Herod Antipas: See "Herod Antipas" Profile. • Antipas's half brother Philip, another son of Herod the Great, was ruler (literally *tetrarch*) of the region northeast of Galilee from 4 BC until his death in AD 34. *Tetrarch* means "the ruler of a fourth of a kingdom"; the term came to mean any minor ruler. Philip the Tetrarch was a half brother of both Antipas and Herod Philip ([Matt 14:3](#); [Mark 6:17](#)).

Luke 3:1–4:13

After the birth narrative, Luke sets the stage for Jesus' public ministry. He tells about the ministry of John the Baptist as forerunner of the Messiah and Jesus' baptism, genealogy, and temptation.

Luke 3:2

Annas and Caiaphas were the high priests: Annas was high priest AD 6–15 and was deposed by the Romans; his son-in-law Caiaphas was the current high priest (AD 18–36). Luke lists both names because Annas still wielded significant power behind the scenes (see [John 18:13–14](#), [24](#); [Acts 4:6](#)). • a message from God came to John: John's calling as a prophet was similar to that of the Old Testament prophets (see, e.g., [Isa 6](#); [Jer 1](#)).

Luke 3:3

people should be baptized to show that they had repented of their sins and turned to God: John seems to have adapted the practice of baptism from Jewish rites using water to cleanse, or set apart, people and objects for God's service (cp. [Lev 8:6](#)). John called people to repent of their sins and prepare spiritually for the Messiah's coming. Their baptism publicly demonstrated their repentance and spiritual cleansing.

Luke 3:4–6

The quotation is from [Isa 40:3–5](#) (Greek version); it speaks of God's delivering the Jews from exile in Babylon. After the Jews had returned from exile ([Ezra 1–2](#)), the passage became associated with God's end-time salvation. John shouted in the wilderness to prepare God's people for the Lord's coming. God's salvation is portrayed as a new exodus, bringing deliverance like the first exodus from Egypt. • Clear the road for him! . . . the rough places made smooth: The image reflects the Middle Eastern practice of preparing a road at the approach of a king, something like "rolling out the red carpet" (cp. [Luke 19:36–38](#)).

Luke 3:7

God's coming wrath is the judgment for all who reject the gospel. Israel as a nation would experience this wrath in the destruction of Jerusalem in AD 70 (see [21:20–23](#)).

Luke 3:8

we are descendants of Abraham: Some Jews believed that their descent from Abraham guaranteed their salvation (see [John 8:33–39](#); [Acts 7:2](#); [Rom 4:1](#)). • That means nothing: God had selected the Israelites as his people, and he could reject them and create children of Abraham from these very stones if he chose (cp. [Hos 1:3–9](#); [Rom 9:6–8](#), [27–28](#); [11:17–21](#)).

Luke 3:9

every tree that does not produce good fruit: Israel would be judged as an unfruitful vineyard (see [Isa 5:1–7](#); cp. [Luke 13:7–9](#); [20:9–19](#)).

Luke 3:11

two shirts: The Greek word refers to a long shirt worn next to the skin. Even the smallest surplus should be shared with others in need.

Luke 3:12

corrupt tax collectors: The word for “corrupt” is not in the Greek, but it accurately expresses the connotation that “tax collector” had for first-century readers. They despised tax collectors, who were notoriously corrupt and worked for the hated Roman authorities.

Luke 3:14

These soldiers were probably not Roman, but local Jewish troops under the authority of Herod Antipas. They might have been assigned to protect the tax collectors. John does not condemn either tax collectors or soldiers but calls them to honesty and integrity.

Luke 3:16

I’m not even worthy to be his slave and untie the straps of his sandals: The untying of sandals was done only by slaves (to make this connection clear, the NLT adds *be his slave and*). John thus greatly honored the Messiah. • baptize you with the Holy Spirit and with fire: The Old Testament prophets predicted that in the last days, God would pour out his Spirit on his people ([Isa 32:15](#), [Ezek 36:28–29](#); [Joel 2:28](#)). This prophecy was at least partially fulfilled on the day of Pentecost ([Acts 2](#)). Fire is an image of judgment (see [Luke 3:9](#)); it also has the power to cleanse and refine God’s people (see [1 Cor 3:10–15](#); cp. [Isa 4:4](#); [Mal 3:2](#)).

Luke 3:17

After being harvested, the kernels of wheat would be beaten off the stalks and then tossed in the air with a winnowing fork to separate them from the chaff. The heavy grain would fall to the ground as the lighter chaff blew away. This is an image of separation for judgment. • never-ending fire: See [Isa 66:24](#).

Luke 3:19–20

Herod Antipas, the ruler of Galilee, divorced his first wife and married Herodias, the wife of his half brother Herod Philip. When John publicly criticized Herod for this sin, Herod imprisoned and later

executed him (cp. [9:9](#); [Mark 6:16–29](#)). Herod’s execution of John is also recorded by the Jewish historian Josephus (*Antiquities* 18.5.2).

Luke 3:21

As he was praying: Luke emphasizes Jesus’ trust and reliance on God in prayer ([5:16](#); [6:12](#); [9:18, 28](#); [11:1](#); [22:32](#), [41](#), [44](#); [23:34](#), [46](#)). • the heavens opened: This image was a sign of God’s presence ([Isa 64:1](#)), divine revelation ([Ezek 1:1](#); [John 1:51](#)), and the end of an age ([Rev 4:1](#); [15:5](#); [19:11](#)).

Luke 3:21–22

Jesus’ baptism marked the beginning of his public ministry and his anointing as the Messiah (the “Anointed One”). The voice of God from heaven confirmed Jesus’ identity and mission.

Luke 3:22

The Spirit might have looked like a dove, or perhaps it descended in a dove-like manner. • You are my dearly loved Son, and you bring me great joy: This statement resonates with [Ps 2:7](#) and [Isa 42:1](#). The former identifies Jesus as the Messiah from David’s line; the latter indicates his role as servant of the Lord. Jesus’ identity was again declared from heaven at his transfiguration ([Luke 9:35](#)).

Luke 3:23

Jesus was about thirty years old: This is the only reference in the New Testament to Jesus’ age during his public ministry, and it is an approximation. Jesus was born 6~4 BC (see study note on 2:2) and began his ministry AD 27~29 (see study note on 3:1), so Jesus was evidently 31~35 years old when he began his public ministry. • known as the son of Joseph: Jesus was the legal but not the biological son of Joseph. • Joseph was the son of Heli: If this is actually Mary’s genealogy (see study note on 3:23–38), then Joseph was Heli’s son-in-law, a possible understanding of the Greek sentence.

Luke 3:23-38

This genealogy reverses Matthew's order ([Matt 1:1-17](#)). Luke lists Jesus' lineage back to Adam, possibly to show Jesus' connection with all humanity as the Son of God ([Luke 3:38](#)). Matthew's genealogy descends from Abraham to Joseph, highlighting Jesus' status as the rightful heir of David's throne and the recipient of God's promises to Abraham. The great differences between the two genealogies have led some to propose that Luke's genealogy is that of Mary (see study note on 3:23), who was probably among Luke's primary sources.

Luke 3:27

Zerubbabel was the governor of Judea appointed by the Persians when the Jews returned from Babylonian exile. He supervised the rebuilding of the Temple ([Ezra 3:2, 8](#)).

Luke 3:31

Nathan was David's third son, born to him in Jerusalem ([2 Sam 5:14](#)); he is not to be confused with Nathan the prophet ([2 Sam 7:2](#)).

Luke 3:32

Boaz was the husband of Ruth the Moabite (see [Ruth 2-4](#)).

Luke 3:38

Seth was the third son of Adam and Eve, born after Cain murdered Abel and God banished him ([Gen 4:25-26](#)). • Adam was the son of God: Adam had no earthly father since God created him. In the temptation that follows, Satan repeatedly says to Jesus, "If you are the Son of God. . . ." Adam, the first son of God, failed when tested, but Jesus, the Son of God in the fullest sense, successfully resisted temptation.

Luke 4:1-13

Satan tempted Jesus to bypass his Father's plan of salvation by taking power and glory for himself. The forty-day temptation in the wilderness

parallels Israel's forty years of testing in the wilderness. Israel failed when tested, but Jesus was victorious.

Luke 4:2

tempted by the devil: The term diabolos is a Greek translation of the Hebrew satan, meaning "accuser" or "adversary" ([1 Chr 21:1](#); [Job 1:1-2:13](#); [Zech 3:1-2](#)). Luke uses both terms ("devil," [Luke 4:3, 6, 13; 8:12](#); "Satan," [10:18; 11:18; 13:16; 22:3, 31](#)). Adam and Eve were tested by Satan and failed; Jesus, the second Adam, resisted temptation and thus reversed the judgment against Adam and Eve.

Luke 4:3

If you are the Son of God: Both Israel and Adam are identified as God's son ([3:38](#); [Exod 4:22-23](#); [Hos 11:1](#)). Jesus, the Son of God in the fullest sense, succeeded where Adam and Israel failed.

Luke 4:4

People do not live by bread alone: Israel complained constantly about hunger in the wilderness, but Jesus depended on God's strength to sustain him.

Luke 4:6

they are mine to give: The New Testament elsewhere describes Satan's limited rule over the present world order ([John 12:31; 14:30; 16:11; Eph 2:2; 1 Jn 5:19](#)).

Luke 4:8

You must worship the Lord your God and serve only him: Israel turned to idolatry when suffering hardship in the wilderness ([Deut 9:12](#)). Jesus refused to worship Satan.

Luke 4:10-11

Having been repulsed twice by Scripture, the devil now quoted Scripture to Jesus, citing a passage that assures God's people of his protection.

Luke 4:12

You must not test the Lord your God: In the wilderness, Israel constantly tested God's faithfulness, but Jesus responded with complete trust in God.

Luke 4:13

The next opportunity might have been Judas's betrayal ([22:3-6](#), [21-22](#), [47-48](#)); the supreme test came at Gethsemane ([22:39-46](#)).

Luke 4:14

Jesus returned to Galilee: The story of Jesus' ministry in Galilee begins here, and continues through [9:50](#). • filled with the Holy Spirit's power: At his baptism, Jesus was anointed and empowered to accomplish his role as the Messiah (see [3:22](#); [4:1](#), [14](#), [18](#)).

Luke 4:16-30

Jesus' sermon in Nazareth previewed his whole public ministry. Jesus returned to his hometown synagogue to announce the good news that God's salvation had now arrived. The people were pleased until Jesus reminded them that God reaches out to Gentiles as well as to Jews. The infuriated crowd then attempted to kill him.

Luke 4:18-19

The time of the Lord's favor refers to the Year of Jubilee ([Lev 25:8-55](#)), when debts were erased, slaves were freed, and land was returned to its original owners. In [Isa 61](#), the Year of Jubilee is a metaphor for God's salvation.

Luke 4:21

has been fulfilled: Jesus announced that because he was present, the new age of salvation had arrived. • this very day! Literally *today*; cp. [2:11](#); [5:26](#); [19:9](#); [23:43](#).

Luke 4:23

Physician, heal yourself was a common proverb in the ancient world. Here it might mean "prove your healing powers," or "help your own people, not just others." • like those you did in Capernaum: See [4:31-44](#).

Luke 4:25-26

widow of Zarephath: See [1 Kgs 17-18](#).

Luke 4:27

Naaman, a Syrian: See [2 Kgs 5](#).

Luke 4:28

The people in the synagogue were furious that Jesus pointed out the favor God had shown to Gentiles. The Jews viewed themselves as sole recipients of God's favor, and they were oppressed by Gentile overlords.

Luke 4:30

he passed right through the crowd: The main emphasis is on the sovereign majesty of Jesus. His time had not yet come (cp. [John 7:30](#), [44](#); [8:20](#), [59](#)). This attempt to kill Jesus anticipated his crucifixion, so his escape foreshadows his resurrection.

Luke 4:31

Jesus moved from Nazareth to make Capernaum his base of operations during his Galilean ministry (see [Mark 2:1](#)).

Luke 4:33

an evil (literally *unclean*) spirit: *Unclean* means “defiled” or “wicked”; hence, the NLT translation “evil spirit.”

Luke 4:34

Have you come to destroy us? Though there was only one demon present, the plural *us* suggests that all of Satan’s forces were aware and fearful of Jesus’ coming. • I know who you are: A common ancient belief held that naming a spiritual power gave a person authority over it. The demon might have been attempting to gain power over Jesus.

Luke 4:36

What authority and power this man’s words possess! Magicians and exorcists often used elaborate rituals and incantations. The people were amazed that Jesus merely spoke a word on his own authority and cast out the demon.

Luke 4:38

Simon’s home: Simon was from Bethsaida ([John 1:44](#)), but his present home and fishing business were in Capernaum. • Simon’s mother-in-law: Peter was married (see [1 Cor 9:5](#)), but his wife is not named.

Luke 4:39

he rebuked the fever: The same Greek word was used when Jesus rebuked the demon ([4:35](#)). Jesus has full authority over physical and spiritual forces.

Luke 4:41

You are the Son of God! This was a title for the Messiah (see [2 Sam 7:14](#); [Pss 2:7](#); [89:26–27](#)). Luke often links the titles “Christ” and “Son of God” ([Luke 9:35](#); [22:66–71](#); [Acts 9:20](#), [22](#)). • he . . . refused to let them speak: Jesus often showed his authority over demons by silencing them. He wanted to reveal his identity in his own way, not through their announcement.

Luke 4:43

The Greek verb translated preach the Good News corresponds to the noun often translated “gospel” (“Good News”; see study note on 2:9–10; see also [1:19](#); [7:22](#); [Matt 4:23](#); [24:14](#); [Mark 1:1](#), [15](#); [16:15](#); [Acts 8:4](#), [12](#); [Rom 1:1–6](#), [15–17](#); [10:15–17](#); [Gal 1:6–9](#); [Eph 2:14–18](#); [3:6–7](#)). • The Kingdom of God was Jesus’ central concern (see [Mark 1:15](#)), and God’s sovereign reign was established through Jesus’ words and deeds.

Luke 4:44

Luke probably used Judea in the general sense of “the land of the Jews,” since Jesus’ ministry was then in Galilee in the north (see [5:1](#)), not south in Judea.

Luke 5:1–11

This is the first call of disciples recorded in Luke; Matthew and Mark recount a (presumably earlier) call of the four fishermen brothers ([Matt 4:18–22](#); [Mark 1:16–20](#)). Jesus demonstrated extraordinary authority in the miraculous catch of fish and in his call of Simon Peter.

Luke 5:3

So he sat in the boat and taught the crowds: By sitting in the boat slightly offshore, Jesus had a platform from which to address the people without being mobbed.

Luke 5:4

let down your nets to catch some fish: Peter was naturally skeptical when a rabbi told fishermen how to catch fish. Jesus’ command was odd for three reasons: (1) When the sun came up, the fish moved to the bottom of the lake (which is why they fished at night); (2) they fished with a heavy dragnet hung over the side of the boat by two men (or between two boats) and could not go deep with it; (3) they had just fished all night with no results, and the prospects were now much more unlikely.

Luke 5:7

Their partners in the other boat were James and John, who with their father Zebedee were business partners with Peter (see [5:10](#); [Mark 1:19–20](#)) and Andrew (see [Mark 1:16](#)). • both boats were filled with fish: This dramatic miracle confirmed Jesus' authority over the forces of nature.

Luke 5:8

I'm such a sinful man: Cp. [Isa 6:5](#).

Luke 5:10

Jesus drew a spiritual analogy between fishing and seeking people for the Kingdom of God.

Luke 5:11

they left everything: Their sacrifice was remarkable in a culture that so highly valued loyalty to family and clan.

Luke 5:12

an advanced case of leprosy: "Leprosy" does not refer specifically to the modern disease known as leprosy (Hansen's disease), but to a variety of skin disorders. To avoid contagion, lepers were outcasts in the ancient world, required to live on the margins of society. The law of Moses set guidelines for the diagnosis and quarantine of leprosy ([Lev 13–14](#)).

Luke 5:13

Jesus reached out and touched him: Most people feared catching the disease through physical contact, but Jesus showed compassion. Jesus was not contaminated by disease or evil, but brought healing and salvation. • Be healed: Literally *Be cleansed*. This act had spiritual and physical significance, since leprosy separated Israelites from social contact and religious practice.

Luke 5:14

Jesus often told those he healed not to tell anyone what had happened to avoid celebrity status. Nonetheless, news of these events spreads like wildfire (see [5:15–16](#); see also "The Secret of the Messiah" Theme Note). • Go to the priest and let him examine you. . . . the offering: Those healed of leprosy had to be declared clean by a priest, and a sacrifice was offered on their behalf.

Luke 5:17

Pharisees: See "The Pharisees" Profile. • Teachers of religious law, also called "scribes" and "lawyers," were experts in interpreting the law of Moses. Most of the scribes were Pharisees, though some were Sadducees.

Luke 5:17–26

The healing of the paralyzed man initiated the conflicts Jesus had with religious leaders throughout his public ministry until he was crucified in Jerusalem.

Luke 5:19

took off some tiles: Palestinian roofs were normally made of wooden beams covered with reeds and mud or clay. Either this roof had tiles, or else Luke was interpreting the episode for his Greek readers (cp. [Mark 2:4](#), which speaks of *digging through* the roof).

Luke 5:22

Jesus knew what they were thinking: While the Pharisees were accusing Jesus of blasphemy, he was reading their minds—something only God can do.

Luke 5:23–24

Jesus showed his authority to forgive sins by healing the man.

Luke 5:24

Son of Man: See “The Son of Man” Theme Note.

Luke 5:27

tax collector: See study note on 3:12. • Levi’s tax collector’s booth was probably a toll booth for goods in transit. • Levi was also called Matthew ([Matt 9:9](#); see “Matthew (Levi)” Profile).

Luke 5:27–32

The call of Levi led to Jesus’ second conflict with the religious leaders, and it introduced the idea that Jesus had come to save sinners.

Luke 5:29

with Jesus as the guest of honor: Matthew introduced Jesus to his friends and colleagues to honor Jesus for calling him as a disciple. It was common in the ancient world to repay honor with honor.

Luke 5:30

Meals were rituals of social status in the ancient world, and eating with someone meant social acceptance of that person. The Pharisees refused to eat with tax collectors and other sinners, or to enter their homes, believing that this would defile them. They expected Jesus, as a rabbi, to do the same. Jesus shattered social norms by dining with sinners and allowing sinful people to touch him ([5:29](#); [7:39](#); [15:1](#)). The religious leaders severely criticized him for this and derisively called him “a friend of tax collectors and other sinners” ([7:34](#)).

Luke 5:31–32

Jesus responded that, like a doctor, his mission was to work with sick people, not the healthy. Jesus was not called to minister to self-righteous people, but to those who recognized their spiritual need for God’s grace and healing.

Luke 5:33

John the Baptist’s disciples: Most rabbis had students who learned from them and served them (see also [Acts 19:1–7](#)). • fast and pray regularly: Many pious Jews fasted two days a week ([Luke 18:12](#)). Fasting was associated with spiritual preparation ([Esth 4:16](#)) and repentance ([2 Sam 12:22](#); [Joel 1:14](#); [Jon 3:5](#)). Fasting is not a means of righteousness ([Isa 58:4–5](#); [Jer 14:12](#)) but a spiritual discipline for cultivating intimacy with God. Fasting is often linked with prayer and spiritual retreat. • Why are your disciples always eating and drinking? The point was that they did not fast regularly.

Luke 5:34–35

Do wedding guests fast? Just as it would be inappropriate for anyone to fast at a wedding celebration, it was inappropriate for people to fast while the Messiah was with them. God’s final salvation is a great wedding feast that God prepares for his people ([Isa 25:6–8](#); [Luke 14:15–24](#)).

Luke 5:36–38

a new garment . . . new wine: New cloth shrinks when washed and so tears the old; new wine expands with fermentation and breaks brittle old wineskins. In either case, both old and new are ruined. Both illustrations make the point that the old is incompatible with the new. Jesus did not come to patch up the old covenant, but to establish a new one. The Kingdom of God brings a whole new orientation to thinking and living.

Luke 5:39

The old is just fine: The religious leaders were resistant to change.

Luke 6:1

his disciples broke off heads of grain: The law allowed this kind of grazing while walking through someone else’s field ([Deut 23:24–25](#)).

Luke 6:1-11

Jesus' conflicts with the religious leaders continued with two controversies over the Sabbath. The law of Moses required Jews to rest on the Sabbath ([Exod 20:8-11](#); [Deut 5:13-14](#)), but the Pharisees had forgotten that the real reason for the Sabbath was to benefit human beings.

Luke 6:2

by harvesting grain: The disciples were not accused of stealing grain, but of working on the Sabbath. They were breaking rules established by oral tradition.

Luke 6:3

While fleeing from Saul ([1 Sam 21](#)), David . . . and his companions took refuge at the sanctuary of Nob. The priest Ahimelech gave them the consecrated Bread of the Presence that only priests were lawfully allowed to eat ([Exod 25:30](#); [Lev 24:9](#)). Jesus' point was that a technical violation of the law is superseded by the higher law of meeting human needs. There might also be a comparison between David and Jesus as God's chosen and anointed kings of Israel.

Luke 6:5

Lord, even over the Sabbath: The saying is a play on words with a double meaning. First, *son of man* often means "human being," so Jesus affirmed that the Sabbath was made to serve human beings. *Son of Man* was also a title for the Messiah (see [Dan 7:13-14](#)). Jesus is Lord of the Sabbath because he created it.

Luke 6:6-7

watched Jesus closely: Jesus now had a reputation for placing human needs above the Sabbath commands, so the religious leaders hoped to catch him working on the Sabbath. • If he healed the man's hand: The rabbis of Jesus' day debated whether offering medical help was justified on the Sabbath; it was generally allowed only in extreme emergencies. The deformed hand was clearly not an emergency.

Luke 6:8

Come and stand in front of everyone: Jesus did not shy away from controversy but was willing to confront the Pharisees' hypocrisy head on.

Luke 6:9

Is this a day to save life or to destroy it? Jesus' question penetrated the religious leaders' motives. They were plotting against Jesus (an evil act) because he was going to heal someone (a good act).

Luke 6:12

he prayed to God all night: See study note on 3:21. Jesus prayed before important events and decisions such as choosing the Twelve, who would carry on his ministry after him.

Luke 6:13

Disciples were students and followers; apostles were specially commissioned representatives. • The number twelve symbolically represents the twelve tribes of Israel. The apostles represented the restored people of God.

Luke 6:14

Simon (whom he named Peter): Peter means "rock" or "stone" (see [Matt 16:18](#)).

Luke 6:15

The diversity of Jesus' apostles is striking. • Matthew, also called Levi, was the tax collector for the Romans (see [5:27](#); [Matt 9:9](#); [10:3](#)). • Simon (who was called the zealot): *Zealot* probably meant that he had joined the Zealot movement, a group of Jews actively seeking to overthrow the Roman government.

Luke 6:16

Judas (son of James) was probably also called Thaddaeus ([Matt 10:3](#); [Mark 3:18](#)). He was a different man than Judas Iscariot or Jude the half brother of Jesus (who wrote the New Testament book of Jude). • Judas Iscariot: *Iscariot* probably means “from Kerioth,” a village twelve miles south of Hebron.

Luke 6:17

all over Judea . . . Tyre and Sidon: Tyre and Sidon were coastal cities on the Mediterranean Sea northwest of Galilee. Jesus was gaining wide popularity.

Luke 6:17–49

The central theme of Jesus’ great sermon is that an authentic life of righteousness accompanies repentance and acceptance into God’s Kingdom.

Luke 6:20–21

poor . . . hungry: Cp. [Matt 5:3](#), [6](#). This statement likely included physical and spiritual poverty. Poverty and suffering tend to make us more dependent on God. The Old Testament includes many promises that God will feed and comfort his people ([Pss 22:26](#); [107:36–41](#); [126:1–6](#); [Isa 49:10–13](#); [51:3](#); [65:13](#)).

Luke 6:20–23

God blesses those who acknowledge their inadequacy and weakness and turn to God for strength. The value system of God’s Kingdom is radically different from the world’s value system, in which power and strength represent success.

Luke 6:23

treated the ancient prophets that same way: See “The Suffering Prophet” Theme Note.

Luke 6:24–26

Promises of blessing for the poor and oppressed are balanced in Luke with predictions of sorrow for the rich and powerful. Those who trust in themselves will be humbled, while those who depend on God will be blessed. The Old Testament prophets often pronounced woes against nations and rulers who oppressed God’s people and rejected his sovereignty (e.g., [Isa 3:11](#); [5:8](#); [Jer 50:27](#); [Zech 11:17](#)).

Luke 6:27

love your enemies! People were commonly taught in the ancient world to love their family and friends and hate their enemies. Jesus announced a radical new ethic of loving even one’s enemies and overcoming evil through self-sacrificial love for others, not through violence and hatred (cp. [Rom 12:14–21](#)).

Luke 6:30

when things are taken away from you, don’t try to get them back: Jesus’ point is that the cycle of hatred and violence that characterizes human nature can only be broken by responding with good, not evil ([Rom 12:17](#)). We win the world through self-sacrificial love. Jesus was not promoting injustice, as though believers should let criminals take advantage of the weak. God established governments to punish evildoers ([Rom 13:1–5](#)).

Luke 6:31

Do to others as you would like them to do to you: While the Golden Rule appears in some form in various religious and philosophical traditions, only in Jesus’ teaching is love for all people, including enemies, the fundamental ethic that governs all behavior.

Luke 6:34–36

The law of Moses prohibited charging interest on loans to other Israelites in order to prevent exploitation of the poor ([Exod 22:25](#); [Lev 25:35–37](#); [Deut 23:20](#)). Jesus further instructed his

followers to lend . . . without expecting to be repaid. By doing good even to those who do evil, we act as children of the Most High and imitate our Father in heaven, who is kind to all people (cp. [Rom 5:8](#)).

Luke 6:37-42

Do not judge others: Jesus condemned hypocritical judgment that denigrated another person. Those who condemn others will be judged by that same standard. God requires his people to love others by warning them of the dangers of sin ([Gal 6:1](#); [Heb 3:13](#)). Exhortation is an act of love; judgment is an act of pride.

Luke 6:38

pressed down, shaken together: A generous grain merchant would top off the buyer's container, press it down, shake it to make more room, and then pour until the grain overflowed into the buyer's lap.

Luke 6:41

a log in your own: Jesus did not say that the speck in our friend's eye is not our business, but that we must first correct our own faults so that we can see clearly enough to remove the speck. Jesus condemned hypocritical judgment; lovingly holding one another accountable regarding sin is desirable.

Luke 6:45

What people take in and treasure determines what will emerge in their lives.

Luke 6:49

anyone who hears and doesn't obey: See [Ezek 33:31-33](#).

Luke 7:1-10

This episode shows God's message of salvation is for Gentiles as well as Jews.

Luke 7:2

a Roman officer (literally *a centurion*): A centurion was in charge of a "century," approximately 100 soldiers. There were 60 centuries, or 6,000 soldiers, in a Roman legion.

Luke 7:3

Jewish elders were leaders in the Jewish community. With his tendency to abbreviate accounts, Matthew has the centurion approaching Jesus ([Matt 8:5-13](#)). Luke tells the full story in which Jewish elders, and later the centurion's friends, act as intermediaries.

Luke 7:5

he loves the Jewish people and even built a synagogue for us: Such patronage by wealthy Gentiles was common in Jewish communities throughout the Roman Empire. It suggests that the centurion might have been a "God-fearer" like Cornelius ([Acts 10:2](#)), a Gentile who worshiped the God of Israel but had not fully converted to Judaism.

Luke 7:6

I am not worthy of such an honor: The man was probably showing sensitivity to Jewish concerns; pious Jews would not enter the home of a Gentile, since it would make them ceremonially unclean (see [Acts 10:28](#); [11:12](#)). The centurion might also have been acknowledging Jesus' superior status.

Luke 7:8

the authority of my superior officers: The Roman army was renowned for its organization and discipline. The centurion recognized authority when he saw it in Jesus' words and actions.

Luke 7:9

I haven't seen faith like this in all Israel! While many in Israel were unresponsive to the good news

of salvation, some Gentiles believed and found salvation.

Luke 7:11

The location of the village of Nain is uncertain; it might be the modern town of Nein, six miles southeast of Nazareth.

Luke 7:11–17

Jesus raised three people from the dead; the others were Jairus's daughter ([8:40–56](#)) and Lazarus ([John 11:38–44](#)). Jesus has authority over life and death (cp. [1 Kgs 17:17–24](#); [2 Kgs 4:18–37](#)).

Luke 7:12

A funeral procession: In Judaism, a large crowd of mourners and intense wailing signified great love for the deceased. Mourners were hired in some cases. • Widows were the most vulnerable members of society, and God had special concern for them ([Exod 22:22](#); [Deut 10:18](#); [27:19](#)). This widow's only son was her means of support and hope for the future; his death was a terrible loss (see [Jer 6:26](#); [Amos 8:10](#); [Zech 12:10](#)).

Luke 7:13–14

The word translated coffin may refer to a casket or a funeral bier. A Jew was rendered unclean by touching a dead body or the coffin or bier ([Lev 21:1, 11–12](#)). As when he touched the man with leprosy ([Luke 5:13](#)), however, Jesus was not defiled. He replaced disease and death with cleansing and life.

Luke 7:16

A mighty prophet: Jesus was like Elijah and Elisha.

Luke 7:18–23

The disciples of John the Baptist: See study note on 5:33. John was now in prison ([3:19–20](#)), wondering whether Jesus was truly the Messiah, since he did not act like a powerful warrior-king who would

overthrow the Romans. In response, Jesus defined his messianic role.

Luke 7:22

the blind see, the lame walk: A series of allusions to Isaiah ([Isa 26:19](#); [29:18–19](#); [35:5–6](#); [61:1–2](#)) defines God's salvation as the restoration of fallen creation. Jesus did not come to overthrow Roman rule over Judea (so he omits "captives . . . will be freed" from his quotation of [Isa 61:1](#)); he came for the greater purpose of reversing the effects of sin and death.

Luke 7:23

God blesses those who do not fall away because of me: The blessing is for those who are able to put aside their personal agendas and preconceived ideas about the Messiah and accept Jesus' path of suffering.

Luke 7:27

The quotation is from [Mal 3:1](#). In [Mal 4:5–6](#), this messenger is identified with the prophet Elijah. Though John denied that he was Elijah ([John 1:21–23](#)), he came in the spirit and power of Elijah ([Luke 1:17](#)) to prepare the way for the Messiah (see [3:4–6](#)).

Luke 7:28

Jesus praised John as the greatest person who ever lived under the old covenant. But even the least person in the Kingdom of God is greater than John. The blessings of the new covenant—free and complete forgiveness of sins, the indwelling presence of the Holy Spirit, and intimate knowledge of God—give believers in Jesus a new and greater position than even John enjoyed.

Luke 7:31–35

To what can I compare the people of this generation? Jesus compares Israel to fickle children in the marketplace who play games of make-believe. They called John the Baptist to dance (a wedding game), but the solemn prophet refused,

calling them instead to mourning and repentance for their sins. Then they called on Jesus to mourn (a funeral game), but he was the bridegroom who announced the joyful celebration banquet of the Kingdom of God, so it would not have been fitting for him to mourn (cp. [Mark 2:19-20](#)).

Luke 7:33

John the Baptist didn't spend his time eating bread or drinking wine: John lived an ascetic's life of self-denial, appropriate to his prophetic role of announcing God's Kingdom, the coming judgment, and the need for repentance and cleansing.

Luke 7:35

But wisdom is shown to be right by the lives of those who follow it (or *But wisdom is justified by all her children*): In Proverbs, Wisdom is personified as a woman who calls God's people to a life of godliness and obedience to God's commands ([Prov 1:20-33](#); [8:1-9:6](#)). Wisdom's children are those who live righteously, as God's word instructs.

Luke 7:36

One of the Pharisees asked Jesus to have dinner with him: Jesus has more positive contact with the Pharisees in Luke than in the other Gospels. He was a respected teacher and healer, so it is not surprising that this Pharisee invited him to dinner. Not all Pharisees were antagonistic—some were interested in his teaching or merely curious.

Luke 7:36-50

Jesus' comment in [7:35](#) is now illustrated by one of "wisdom's children" (see study note on 7:35), a repentant sinner who shows gratitude for the forgiveness she has received.

Luke 7:37

a certain immoral woman: The implication is that she was a prostitute. • Alabaster is a soft marble—white, yellow, or red—that was often used to make expensive containers like this beautiful . . . jar.

Luke 7:38

she knelt behind him at his feet: At a banquet, guests reclined around a low table with their feet extended outward. The woman could not reach Jesus' head to anoint him, so she poured the perfume on his feet. • wiped them off with her hair: Letting down her hair in public was scandalous and could have constituted grounds for her husband to divorce her; kissing his feet connoted reverence. She discarded propriety due to her gratitude.

Luke 7:40

Then Jesus answered his thoughts: See study note on 5:22.

Luke 7:41

500 pieces of silver (denarii) was almost two years' wages for a day laborer. The poor were often heavily indebted to the wealthy in first-century Galilee.

Luke 7:43

the one for whom he canceled the larger debt: Those who had been forgiven the most responded with greater gratitude and love. The woman did her extraordinary act of sacrificial love because Jesus had forgiven her sins.

Luke 7:44-46

Simon had neglected to show Jesus the common courtesies of hospitality. Since roads were dusty, a servant would wash the dust from a guest's feet. Greeting a guest with a kiss on both cheeks is normal in the Middle East even today. Anointing the head with olive oil was a way to honor a respected guest.

Luke 7:47

so she has shown me much love: This is a better translation than the traditional "because she loved much." It was not that her great love for Jesus

caused him to forgive her, but that the forgiveness she had already received from Jesus prompted her love.

Luke 8:2

Magdalene means “from Magdala,” a village north of Tiberias on the western side of the Sea of Galilee. Mary figures prominently in the burial and resurrection accounts ([24:10](#); [Mark 15:40, 47](#); [John 19:25](#); [20:1, 18](#)). Some have said that Mary Magdalene was the woman of [Luke 7:36–38](#), leading to the belief that she was a former prostitute. There is no basis for this speculation.

Luke 8:2–3

along with some women: Rabbis of Jesus’ day did not have women disciples, so this was unusual. Some of these women, like Joanna, were from wealthy families and contributed financially to Jesus’ ministry.

Luke 8:4–15

The parable of the farmer scattering seed depicts people’s varied responses to Jesus’ ministry of proclaiming God’s Kingdom.

Luke 8:5

The custom in planting was first to scatter seed and then to plow it into the soil. • The seed that fell on a footpath running through the fields would not be plowed in, so it was stepped on and eaten by birds.

Luke 8:6

fell among rocks: Often there was a limestone layer nine to twelve inches under the soil, so that the rain was trapped and seed sprouted quickly in the moist soil. But when the rain stopped, the sun evaporated the trapped moisture and the plant died.

Luke 8:7

fell among thorns: One type of weed looked very much like wheat as it grew, but it had larger roots and took away the moisture and nutrients that the wheat needed.

Luke 8:8

Anyone with ears to hear meant everyone who was willing to listen.

Luke 8:10

the secrets of the Kingdom of God: What was hidden in the past about God’s reign was now revealed through Jesus’ words and actions. • When they look . . . they won’t understand: This quote is from [Isa 6:9](#) (Greek version), a passage repeatedly used in the New Testament to explain Israel’s rejection of the gospel (see also [Matt 13:14–15](#); [Mark 4:12](#); [John 12:40](#); [Acts 28:26–27](#)). In its original context, the passage refers to God’s certain judgment of Israel at the hands of the Assyrians. Israel’s sin and rebelliousness had taken them beyond the point of no return, so God blinded them in preparation for judgment. Those who rejected Jesus’ message were blind to the truth.

Luke 8:11

The seed is God’s word: This refers to Jesus’ preaching of the Good News of the Kingdom.

Luke 8:12

to have the devil come and take it away: Satan seeks to prevent unbelievers from seeing the truth.

Luke 8:13

Deep roots indicate spiritual depth and maturity. The Greek word translated temptation can also mean “testing” or “trials.”

Luke 8:16–17

A small clay lamp was filled with olive oil and set in a wall alcove. Jesus' message provides light for those who listen, and it reveals their heart attitudes.

Luke 8:18

those who listen: Cp. [Prov 9:9](#).

Luke 8:19–20

Jesus had four brothers—James, Joseph, Judas, and Simon—and an unknown number of sisters ([Matt 13:55](#); [Mark 6:3](#)). These children were probably born to Joseph and Mary after Jesus' virginal conception and birth. (On the other hand, some believe that Mary remained a lifelong virgin and that Joseph was therefore a widower with children from a previous marriage when he married Mary.)

Luke 8:21

those who hear God's word and obey it: Jesus was not rejecting his family but announcing that spiritual relationships—being part of God's family—supersede family ties.

Luke 8:22–25

Jesus' calming of the storm demonstrated his authority over nature and strongly indicated his deity, since God is master of the seas (see [Pss 65:7](#); [89:9](#); [104:6–7](#); [107:23–32](#)).

Luke 8:23

a fierce storm came down on the lake: Severe storms are common on the Sea of Galilee, which lies in a valley surrounded by high hills.

Luke 8:24

he rebuked the wind and the raging waves: As Jesus rebuked demons ([4:41](#)) and diseases ([4:39](#)), so now he revealed his authority by rebuking the sea

(cp. [2 Sam 22:16](#); [Pss 18:15](#); [104:7](#); [106:9](#); [Isa 50:2](#); [Nah 1:4](#)).

Luke 8:26

the region of the Gerasenes: Gerasa was a city of the Decapolis, thirty miles southeast of the Sea of Galilee. Jesus deliberately went to a predominantly Gentile region and ministered there.

Luke 8:26–39

This exorcism story demonstrated Jesus' authority over spiritual forces. It also contrasted the faith and devotion of the freed man with the fear and rejection of the townspeople.

Luke 8:27

living in the tombs outside the town: Touching a tomb or a dead body rendered a Jew unclean, or ceremonially defiled. Jesus willingly entered this unclean place to rescue a person enslaved by Satan.

Luke 8:28

Jesus, Son of the Most High God: See study notes on 4:34, 41.

Luke 8:29

evil (literally *unclean*) spirit: Unclean things are unfit for God's presence (see also study note on 4:33).

Luke 8:30

A Roman legion had about 6,000 soldiers, so this man had a great many demons.

Luke 8:31

the bottomless pit: The Greek word *abussos* means "bottomless" and often refers to the underworld prison of evil spirits or fallen angels ([Rev 9:1–2](#), [11](#); [11:7](#); [17:8](#); [20:1](#), [3](#); cp. [2 Pet 2:4](#)). The metaphor is

taken from the apparently bottomless depth of the ocean (the ancients had no means for sounding the ocean depths, so to them it was bottomless).

Luke 8:32

a large herd of pigs: Pigs were unclean animals for Jews, which shows that the people of this region were Gentiles. The unclean demons were fit only for pigs.

Luke 8:35

sitting at Jesus' feet: The man sat in the position of a disciple, indicating his willingness to follow Jesus (see [8:37](#)).

Luke 8:37

begged Jesus to go away: Jesus' power over spiritual forces frightened the townspeople, and their loss of property (the pigs) angered them. Their rejection contrasts with the faith of the healed man.

Luke 8:39

go back to your family: The role of disciples is to proclaim to the world what Jesus has done for them.

Luke 8:40–56

These two accounts of healing demonstrate Jesus' authority over disease and death, and illustrate the power of faith.

Luke 8:41

The leader of the local synagogue was the officer who maintained the local synagogue and organized services (see also [8:49](#); [13:14](#); [Acts 13:15](#); [18:8, 17](#)).

Luke 8:43

with constant bleeding: Perhaps it was a menstrual disorder. The tragedy was both physical and spiritual, for such bleeding rendered the woman ceremonially unclean and thereby precluded her participation in community worship ([Lev 15:25–30](#)).

Luke 8:44

The fringe of his robe probably refers to the tassels that pious Jews wore on the edges of their robes (see [Num 15:38–39](#); [Deut 22:12](#)).

Luke 8:45

Who touched me? Jesus recognized the touch of faith by a needy person.

Luke 8:48

Your faith has made you well (literally *your faith has saved you*). Go in peace: Jesus said the same thing to the woman who had anointed his feet ([7:50](#)). The Greek word for “save” can indicate either spiritual or physical healing. Peace (cp. Hebrew shalom) refers to wholeness, not just lack of conflict (see [1:79](#); [2:14](#), [29](#); [7:50](#); [19:38](#), [42](#); [24:36](#)).

Luke 8:51

Peter, John, and James became the inner circle of Jesus' disciples (see [5:1–11](#); [9:28](#); [Mark 14:32–33](#)).

Luke 8:52

The house was filled with people weeping and wailing: See study note on 7:12. • she's only asleep: Jesus emphasized the temporary nature of the girl's state. For believers, death is only temporary “sleep” (cp. [John 11:11](#); the same term is translated as “dead/died” in [Acts 7:60](#); [13:36](#); [1 Cor 11:30](#); [15:6, 18, 20, 51](#); [1 Thes 4:14–15](#); [5:10](#)).

Luke 8:55

her life returned: Like the raising of the widow's son ([7:15](#)), the girl's normal mortal life was restored. At the final resurrection, believers will receive immortal, glorified bodies (see study note on 24:39).

Luke 8:56

not tell anyone: See "The Secret of the Messiah" Theme Note.

Luke 9:1-6

Jesus now sent his twelve disciples to announce the Kingdom of God and demonstrate its authority by casting out demons and healing the sick. Jesus was training them to carry on his work after he was gone.

Luke 9:3

Take nothing for your journey: They were to live in dependence on God and on the charity of those to whom they ministered.

Luke 9:4

stay in the same house: They were to develop lasting relationships and be content without seeking better lodging or provisions.

Luke 9:5

shake its dust from your feet: Using a symbol of rejection, they were to leave such a town to the judgment it deserved.

Luke 9:8

Jews expected that Elijah would come prior to God's final judgment (see study note on 1:17). Some Jews expected that a prophet like Moses would come ([Deut 18:15](#)).

Luke 9:9

I beheaded John: See [Mark 6:14-29](#).

Luke 9:10

he slipped quietly away: Jesus knew that the disciples needed a time of spiritual retreat. • The town of Bethsaida was located on the northern shore of the Sea of Galilee, east of the Jordan River. It was the hometown of Peter, Andrew ([John 1:44](#)), and Philip ([John 12:21](#)).

Luke 9:10-17

The feeding of the 5,000 recalls God's miraculous feeding of Israel with manna in the wilderness ([Exod 16](#); see also [2 Kgs 4:42-44](#)). It points forward to God's final salvation as a great feast for all nations ([Isa 25:6-8](#); [65:13-14](#); [Luke 14:15-24](#)).

Luke 9:11

He welcomed them: Although Jesus wished to retreat with his disciples, he had compassion on the crowds and ministered to them.

Luke 9:13

You feed them: After their ministry of healing the sick and casting out demons, Jesus wanted the disciples to demonstrate faith in God's ability to feed the crowds.

Luke 9:17

twelve baskets of leftovers: God abundantly provides for his people.

Luke 9:18-27

Peter's confession that Jesus was the Messiah marked a turning point, as Jesus moved from demonstrating his messianic authority through miracles to explaining the unexpected suffering of the Messiah. Jesus accepted the confession but clarified that his being the Messiah would involve

suffering and death. He called his disciples to follow him regardless of the cost.

Luke 9:19

some say Elijah: See study note on 9:8.

Luke 9:20

the Messiah: The phrase could be translated “the Lord’s Anointed,” a designation for the king of Israel ([1 Sam 24:6](#), [10](#); [2 Sam 19:21](#); [Ps 2:2](#)). David was the Lord’s anointed, as was the Messiah.

Luke 9:21–22

not to tell anyone who he was: Jesus did not want to encourage a popular uprising; his calling was not to overthrow Rome, but to suffer and die.

Luke 9:22

must suffer many terrible things: This was the first of Jesus’ prophecies concerning his coming death in Jerusalem (see [9:44](#); [17:25](#); [18:31–34](#)). Jesus would fulfill [Isa 52:13–53:12](#), in which the servant of the Lord (the Messiah) became a saving sacrifice for God’s people. These events were part of God’s purpose and plan. Despite opposition from human beings and from the spiritual forces of Satan, God works through the actions of human beings to accomplish his purposes. Though wicked men plotted against Jesus and put him to death, God accomplished salvation by raising Jesus from the dead ([Luke 24:7](#), [26–27](#), [44–47](#); [Acts 2:23–24](#); [3:18](#); [4:28](#)). • leading priests: Though Israel had only one high priest, the upper-class priests were the aristocracy; they served on the Sanhedrin and held positions of power in Jerusalem.

Luke 9:23

take up your cross daily: This did not simply mean carrying a heavy burden, but suffering a violent death by crucifixion. Believers must be completely willing to die to themselves and to live for God, even at the cost of their lives.

Luke 9:23–27

If any of you wants to be my follower: After predicting his own suffering and death, Jesus taught that all who follow him must also experience death to self.

Luke 9:24

hang on to your life: Placing oneself on the throne denies Jesus. The result is to lose one’s life, mainly at the last judgment ([9:26](#); [John 12:25](#)).

Luke 9:26

the Son of Man . . . when he returns in his glory: See [Dan 7:13–14](#); “The Son of Man” Theme Note.

Luke 9:27

This difficult verse has been interpreted as referring to: (1) the second coming of Christ; (2) the destruction of Jerusalem in AD 70; (3) the resurrection of Jesus; or (4) the transfiguration, which follows in [9:28–36](#). The last possibility is the most likely.

Luke 9:28

About eight days later: Mark says “after six days,” referring to full days, while Luke includes parts of days. • Peter, John, and James were the inner circle of Jesus’ disciples (see also [8:51](#); [Mark 14:32–33](#)). • a mountain: The site of the transfiguration is traditionally regarded as Mount Tabor in southern Galilee. Some have suggested Mount Hermon, which is closer to Caesarea Philippi, where Peter’s confession ([Luke 9:18–27](#)) took place.

Luke 9:28–36

At the transfiguration, Jesus’ true glory was unveiled for three disciples to witness, confirming Peter’s confession that Jesus was the Christ. Moses and Elijah confirmed that Jesus fulfilled the Old Testament prophecies concerning the Messiah.

Luke 9:29

his clothes became dazzling white (literally *became bright as a flash of lightning*): Jesus' glory shone through his human body (cp. [Ezek 1:4](#); [Dan 7:9](#); see also [Exod 34:29](#)).

Luke 9:31

his exodus from this world: The Greek word *exodos* means "departure." As the exodus from Egypt was God's great act of deliverance in the Old Testament, so Jesus' exodus from this world—his death, resurrection, and ascension—was God's great act of deliverance in the New Testament. Jesus would accomplish a new and greater exodus.

Luke 9:33

Let us put up three shelters: The Greek word translated *shelter* (*skēnē*) is the same word used in the Greek Old Testament for the *tabernacle*. This was Israel's tent for worship that they moved with them as they traveled in the wilderness. It also refers to the temporary *shelters* that Jews used during the Feast of Booths ([Leviticus 23:42](#); [Nehemiah 8:14–17](#)). Peter might have wanted to extend the event by providing a place for Jesus, Moses, and Elijah to stay.

Luke 9:34

a cloud overshadowed them: Clouds often veil the presence of God ([Exod 16:10](#); [19:9](#); [24:16](#)).

Luke 9:35

The voice from the cloud recalls God's voice at Jesus' baptism ([3:22](#)). • *My Chosen One* alludes to [Isa 42:1](#), identifying Jesus as the suffering servant of the Lord. • Listen to him is from [Deut 18:15](#), identifying Jesus as "the prophet like Moses" (see [Acts 3:22](#); [7:37](#)).

Luke 9:38

my only child: The loss of an only son was especially tragic, since this left no one to carry on

the family name (cp. [7:12](#); see [Gen 22:16](#); [1 Kgs 17:17–24](#); [Jer 6:26](#); [Amos 8:10](#); [Zech 12:10](#)).

Luke 9:39

An evil spirit keeps seizing him: Demons sometimes inflict physical illnesses such as lameness ([13:11](#)) and muteness ([11:14](#)).

Luke 9:41

You faithless and corrupt people: It is unclear whether Jesus was speaking to the disciples or to the people as a whole.

Luke 9:44

See study note on 9:22.

Luke 9:45

Its significance was hidden from them: The disciples were often slow to understand, partly because their eyes were blinded to the truth until after the resurrection (see study note on Mark 6:52).

Luke 9:46

Jesus had just predicted his own suffering and death, so the disciples' arguing about which of them was the greatest showed astonishing pride and insensitivity.

Luke 9:46–50

The disciples' failure to apprehend Jesus' impending death was now illustrated by their pride and selfishness.

Luke 9:47

Jesus knew their thoughts: See [5:22](#); [7:39–40](#).

Luke 9:48

Anyone who welcomes a little child: To welcome means to bestow honor and to treat as a social equal. The statement is shocking, since children in Jesus' day had no social status in the community and were viewed as their parents' property. Jesus took the lowest and most vulnerable members of society and announced that welcoming them was equivalent to welcoming him. • on my behalf (literally *in my name*): This means "as my representative." • Whoever is the least among you is the greatest: True leadership in Jesus' Kingdom is achieved through sacrificial service, not the exercise of power (see also [Mark 10:42–45](#)).

Luke 9:50

Anyone who is not against you is for you: Though not one of the Twelve, the man who was casting out demons was not to be discouraged since he, too, was proclaiming the message of the Kingdom. The statement was proverbial, however, and not an absolute truth, as Jesus made the inverse statement in [11:23](#). Wisdom is needed to apply a proverb properly in a given situation.

Luke 9:51

Jesus resolutely set out for Jerusalem: Though the route was indirect, Jerusalem was Jesus' ultimate destination.

Luke 9:51–19:44

Jesus' journey to Jerusalem was a new phase in the suffering mission of the Messiah. In this section, Jesus prepared his disciples for what was to come, while the opposition from the Jewish leaders increased.

Luke 9:52–53

a Samaritan village: Jews and Samaritans had a history of conflict and racial prejudice; they hated each other (see study note on 10:33). The Samaritans, who worshiped on Mount Gerizim, probably assumed that Jesus was traveling to Jerusalem to worship there.

Luke 9:54

call down fire from heaven to burn them up: Some manuscripts add *as Elijah did*. Three times, Elijah called down fire from heaven against the enemies of God ([1 Kgs 18:38](#); [2 Kgs 1:1–17](#)). In their zeal, James and John wanted to do the same.

Luke 9:57–62

As he traveled toward Jerusalem to suffer and die, Jesus explained the cost to those who wished to follow him.

Luke 9:58

no place even to lay his head: Any disciple of Jesus must be ready to go anywhere and to give up home and security.

Luke 9:59

let me . . . bury my father: Respect for parents was a very important value in first-century Israel. Among other things, this meant providing them with an honorable burial. Jesus called for a commitment that took precedence over all human relationships.

Luke 9:61–62

let me say good-bye to my family: The statement echoes Elisha's request of Elijah ([1 Kgs 19:19–20](#)). Jesus required an even more complete commitment from his disciples. • puts a hand to the plow and then looks back: The ancient farmer guided a light plow with his left hand and his oxen with the right. Looking away would turn the plow out of its path. For a believer, looking back meant placing earthly concerns ahead of God.

Luke 10:1–20

The Lord now chose seventy-two: The mission of the Twelve ([9:1–6](#)) represented Jesus' ministry to Israel; this mission represented his outreach to the Gentiles. The number 72 represents the nations of the world. [Genesis 10](#) lists 70 nations in the Hebrew text, but the Septuagint—the Greek Old

Testament—lists 72. Luke, who used the Septuagint, probably wrote 72, and then a later scribe “corrected” the text to agree with the Hebrew. The point is that the Good News is for both Jews and Gentiles.

Luke 10:2

The harvest refers to people who need to hear the Good News and be gathered to God’s presence (cp. [Isa 27:12](#)). There was urgency to the task, just as crops have to be brought in at the exact time when they are ripe. More workers were needed.

Luke 10:3

lambs among wolves: Jesus’ followers are not to dominate others, but to sacrifice themselves for the benefit of others. This makes them vulnerable (see [Jer 5:6](#); [Ezek 22:27](#); [Hab 1:8](#); [Zeph 3:3](#)), but the Good Shepherd ([Ps 23:1](#)) protects them from the wolves.

Luke 10:4

Don’t take any money with you: Cp. [9:3](#). Jesus’ disciples were to depend on God and on the help of those whom they served. • don’t stop to greet anyone on the road: This did not mean being antisocial, but staying focused on the task Jesus had given them.

Luke 10:5

God’s peace means spiritual blessings and wholeness, the shalom of God (see study note on 8:48).

Luke 10:7

Don’t move around from home to home: See study note on 9:4. • because those who work deserve their pay: Those who minister for Jesus should receive compensation from those they serve (see also [1 Cor 9:14](#); [1 Tim 5:18](#)).

Luke 10:9

The same mission was given to the Twelve (see [9:1](#)). • Heal the sick: Healing was a sign of salvation ([Isa 29:18–19](#); [35:5](#)); it was physical evidence that the Kingdom of God was present (see study note on Luke 7:22).

Luke 10:11

See study note on 9:5.

Luke 10:12

God destroyed Sodom and Gomorrah because of their wickedness ([Gen 18:16–19:29](#)).

Luke 10:13

Korazin and Bethsaida, two of the towns in which Jesus ministered, were located on the northern shore of the Sea of Galilee. • Tyre and Sidon were Gentile cities in Phoenicia, on the Mediterranean coast north of Galilee. The prophets had pronounced messages of judgment against their wickedness ([Isa 23](#); [Ezek 28](#)).

Luke 10:15

Capernaum was Jesus’ base of operations during his Galilean ministry; this town saw many of his miracles (see [4:31–41](#)). • to the place of the dead: Though Capernaum was blessed by the Messiah’s presence, it would be judged for its pride and rejection of Jesus.

Luke 10:18

I saw Satan fall from heaven like lightning! See [Rev 12:7–12](#).

Luke 10:19

Snakes and scorpions were symbols of danger and evil (see [Num 21:6–9](#); [Deut 8:15](#); [1 Kgs 12:14](#); [Isa 11:8](#); [Ezek 2:6](#)). Satan is the ancient serpent who tempted Eve ([Gen 3:13–14](#); [Rom 16:20](#); [Rev 12:9](#); [20:2](#)), and demonic forces are described as

scorpions ([Rev 9:3-4](#)). • Nothing will injure you: This didn't mean that Jesus' followers should take dangerous chances. The point is that God protects his servants (e.g., [Acts 28:3-6](#)).

Luke 10:20

Disciples should not rejoice in their spiritual power, but in the greatness of God who freely gives them salvation. • your names are registered in heaven: For the record of salvation in heaven's books, see [Exod 32:32-33](#); [Ps 69:28](#); [Isa 4:3](#); [Dan 12:1](#); [Mal 3:16-17](#); [Phil 4:3](#); [Heb 12:23](#); [Rev 3:5](#); [13:8](#); [17:8](#); [20:12](#), [15](#); [21:27](#).

Luke 10:21

hiding these things: God uses simple things that a child can understand to shame those who think themselves wise but are foolish in God's eyes (see [Isa 29:14](#); [1 Cor 1:18-31](#)).

Luke 10:22

The Father and the Son share an intimate relationship. Jesus came to earth to reveal the Father to a lost world (see [John 1:1-18](#)).

Luke 10:23

that see what you have seen: The disciples witnessed the arrival of God's promised salvation, the inauguration of the Kingdom of God.

Luke 10:25

an expert in religious law: See study note on 5:17.

Luke 10:27

You must love the Lord your God: Jesus identified [Deut 6:5](#) and [Lev 19:18](#) as the two greatest commandments ([Mark 12:28-34](#)). [Deuteronomy 6:5](#) is part of the prayer known as the *Shema*, which every Jew was to repeat daily.

Luke 10:28

Do this and you will live! Jesus was not suggesting that people would be saved by their works; rather, such love expresses genuine faith and devotion to the Lord.

Luke 10:29

who is my neighbor? A neighbor, in this context, was normally identified as a fellow Israelite.

Luke 10:30

The road from Jerusalem down to Jericho dropped 3,300 feet (1,000 meters) through rugged terrain where robbers often lay in wait for travelers.

Luke 10:30-37

Jesus' parable shows that true neighbors love even their enemies ([10:29](#)). Authentic spirituality is not based on ethnic identity or religious associations, but on love for God and for others.

Luke 10:31

a priest: Priests were descendants of Aaron from the tribe of Levi ([Exod 28:1-3](#)). They served in the Temple and offered sacrifices to God. • passed him by: A priest or a Levite became unclean and unable to serve in the Temple if he touched a dead body. This priest was unwilling to risk ritual impurity by helping a person in desperate trouble.

Luke 10:32

A Temple assistant (literally a *Levite*): Levites were members of the tribe of Levi. They were not given a tribal homeland in Israel but were dedicated to God ([Num 3:41, 45](#); [8:18](#); [35:2-3](#); [Deut 18:1](#); [Josh 14:3](#)) as assistants to the priests in the service of the Temple.

Luke 10:33

a despised Samaritan: This reversal in the story must have left the listeners aghast. Jews and

Samaritans hated each other (see [9:52–53](#); [17:16](#); [John 4:4–42](#)). After the Assyrians conquered the northern kingdom of Israel, Assyrian colonists intermarried with Israelites left in Samaria; these inhabitants became known as Samaritans. After the Judeans returned from Babylon, conflict arose between the Jews and the Samaritans ([Ezra 4:1–24](#)), who built a rival temple on Mount Gerizim and used their own version of the Pentateuch (Genesis—Deuteronomy) as their Scripture. Hatred between the two increased dramatically when the Jewish king John Hyrcanus attacked the Samaritans and destroyed the temple on Mount Gerizim (about 128 BC). In this context of mutual animosity, no first-century Jew would expect a despised Samaritan to help a wounded Jew. But in God's Kingdom, a despised foreigner becomes a helping neighbor!

Luke 10:34

Oil soothed the wound; wine was a disinfectant.

Luke 10:38–42

Martha . . . Mary and their brother Lazarus were good friends of Jesus who lived in Bethany, east of Jerusalem (see [John 11:1](#)).

Luke 10:39

Mary . . . sat at the Lord's feet in the position of a disciple (cp. [Acts 22:3](#)). Rabbis did not usually have female disciples.

Luke 10:40

Martha was distracted by the big dinner she was preparing: Hospitality was valued highly, and Martha was fulfilling the expected role of a woman. She was frustrated that Mary was not.

Luke 10:42

There is only one thing worth being concerned about. Mary has discovered it: Jesus' words were shocking. Women were expected to serve domestically and were forbidden to learn as

disciples from a rabbi. Jesus validated Mary's desire to be his disciple.

Luke 11:1

praying: See study note on 3:21.

Luke 11:2–4

This is how you should pray: The "Lord's Prayer" was a model for Jesus' disciples to follow.

Luke 11:4

And don't let us yield to temptation: This is a difficult phrase in the Greek. God does not tempt his people ([Jas 1:13](#)), but since testing is a growth-producing part of our Christian life ([Jas 1:2–4](#)), should believers pray to avoid it? The phrase probably means "protect us during temptation."

Luke 11:6

A friend of mine has just arrived for a visit: Standards of hospitality in first-century Jewish culture required a host to find adequate provisions for a visitor.

Luke 11:8

because of your shameless persistence (or *in order to avoid shame*, or *so his reputation won't be damaged*): Shame would also lie on the man who didn't want to get up, since hospitality was a community requirement. God protects his good name by providing for his people.

Luke 11:11–12

A fish and an egg were common foods. A scorpion resembles an egg when it curls into a ball to lure its prey. Giving a snake or a scorpion would be a cruel practical joke, substituting something deadly for a good meal. No loving father would do such a thing.

Luke 11:13

give the Holy Spirit: Matthew's parallel ([Matt 7:11](#)) reads "give good gifts." The Holy Spirit is the greatest gift for believers, providing guidance, power, and the seal of salvation. Luke gives special prominence to the work of the Holy Spirit in Luke and Acts.

Luke 11:14

a demon from a man who couldn't speak: Demons sometimes inflict physical disease or disability.

Luke 11:14-32

Jesus faced two challenges. He answered the first, an accusation that he was casting out demons by Satan's power ([11:15](#)), in [11:17-26](#). The second was a demand for miraculous signs ([11:16](#)), which he answered in [11:29-32](#).

Luke 11:15

Satan: Greek Beelzeboul ("Baal, the prince"), the name of a Canaanite god that later came to be used as a name for Satan. The Jews mocked the name, calling him *Beelzebub* ("lord of the flies").

Luke 11:17

He knew their thoughts: See [5:22](#); [7:40](#); [9:47](#). • Any kingdom divided by civil war: Jesus' first response to the accusation was that he could not be working for Satan; he was tearing down Satan's kingdom by casting out demons.

Luke 11:20

the Kingdom of God has arrived among you: Jesus' exorcisms were evidence that the Kingdom of God was present.

Luke 11:21-22

The strong man is Satan; the stronger man is Jesus. Jesus' exorcisms demonstrated that he was

defeating and plundering Satan's property—those people held in bondage by him (cp. [Isa 49:24-26](#)).

Luke 11:23

Anyone who isn't with me opposes me: See study note on 9:50.

Luke 11:26

seven other spirits: Seven may indicate completeness, meaning that the man was completely under their power, or it could simply indicate an overwhelming force.

Luke 11:28

even more blessed: Jesus again affirmed that our spiritual life and our relationship with God are more important than physical ancestry and family relationships (cp. [8:21](#)).

Luke 11:29-30

The sign of Jonah could refer to the resurrection; Jonah's time in the fish was a sign to the Ninevites that God had sent him, like Jesus' time in the grave (see [Matt 12:40](#)). It could simply mean that Jonah and Jesus both preached God's warning to repent (see [Luke 11:32](#)).

Luke 11:31

Sheba was a kingdom in southern Arabia. The queen traveled a great distance to hear the wisdom of Solomon ([1 Kgs 10:1-13](#); [2 Chr 9:1-12](#)).

Luke 11:33

No one lights a lamp and then hides it: See study note on 8:16-17.

Luke 11:35-36

Light and darkness are metaphors for good and evil ([John 1:5](#); [3:19](#); [8:12](#); [12:35](#); [Acts 26:18](#); [Rom](#)

[13:12](#); [2 Cor 4:6](#); [6:14](#); [Eph 5:8](#); [1 Thes 5:5](#); [1 Pet 2:9](#); [1 Jn 1:5](#); [2:8-9](#)).

Luke 11:37

one of the Pharisees invited him home for a meal:
See study note on 7:36.

Luke 11:38

the hand-washing ceremony required by Jewish custom: The Pharisees had developed elaborate washing rituals to ensure ceremonial purity (see [Mark 7:1-5](#)).

Luke 11:39

The Pharisees had meticulous rules for ceremonially cleaning cups and utensils for religious purity. Jesus accused them of cleaning only the outside of the cup (following external rules) but leaving the inside . . . filthy (keeping unrighteousness in their hearts).

Luke 11:41

by giving gifts to the poor: Acts of love reveal internal righteousness.

Luke 11:42

tithe even the tiniest income from your herb gardens: Tithing was required by the law ([Lev 27:30-33](#); [Num 18:21-32](#); [Deut 14:22-29](#); [2 Chr 31:5-12](#)). The Pharisees were meticulous in making sure that everything was properly tithed, but they ignored the more important issues—justice and the love of God.

Luke 11:42-52

What sorrow awaits you Pharisees! Woes are the opposite of blessings (see study note on 6:24-26). Jesus pronounced six woes, three against the Pharisees ([11:42](#), [43](#), [44](#)) and three against the teachers of religious law ([11:46](#), [47](#), [52](#)).

Luke 11:43

The elders of the synagogues had special seats of honor. • The respectful greetings were honorable ways of addressing social and religious superiors (like addressing a judge as “your honor”).

Luke 11:44

hidden graves in a field: Touching a grave or a dead body rendered a Jew ceremonially unclean. Jesus accused the religious leaders of being a defiling influence rather than a purifying one. This was a strongly offensive accusation ([11:45](#)).

Luke 11:45

an expert in religious law: The experts in religious law were closely aligned with the Pharisees and shared the same zeal for keeping the law of Moses.

Luke 11:46

unbearable religious demands: This refers to the oral tradition with all its intricate details on living according to *torah* (God’s instruction in the books of Moses). The oral tradition placed a great burden upon the Jewish people.

Luke 11:48

They killed the prophets: See [1 Kgs 19:10, 14](#); [Neh 9:26](#); [Jer 2:30](#); [26:20-24](#). Luke portrays Jesus as “The Suffering Prophet” [Luke 4:22-24](#).

Luke 11:49

The quotation is not explicitly from the Old Testament.

Luke 11:51

from the murder of Abel to the murder of Zechariah: Abel’s murder by his brother Cain was the first murder recorded in the Old Testament ([Gen 4:8](#)). The stoning of Zechariah, son of Jehoiada ([2 Chr 24:20-22](#)) was the last, since Chronicles is the last book in the Hebrew Bible.

Luke 11:52

the key to knowledge: See [Matt 16:19](#); [23:13](#).

Luke 12:1

Yeast permeates dough until it is entirely leavened. Leaven became a symbol for the permeating power of sin ([Exod 12:14–20](#); [1 Cor 5:6](#)). Like yeast, the hypocrisy of the Pharisees would spread until it affected all the people.

Luke 12:2–3

These verses are a warning against hypocrisy. All thoughts will be revealed by God, who knows all things and will judge every human being ([Job 10:4–7](#); [11:11](#); [Pss 11:4](#); [33:15](#); [139:12](#); [Prov 15:3](#)).

Luke 12:5

hell (Greek Gehenna): The Valley of Hinnom was a ravine along the southwestern side of Jerusalem. It became a metaphor for hell because Israelites had offered their children as sacrifices there ([Jer 32:35](#)) and later used it as a place to burn garbage ([Jer 19:2](#), [10–13](#)). Jesus' disciples should never be afraid of enemies who can only take away their life on earth. Instead, they should fear God, who can give eternal punishment.

Luke 12:6

The two copper coins were each worth about half an hour's work for a day laborer.

Luke 12:8

will also acknowledge: At the final judgment (see [Dan 7:7–14](#)).

Luke 12:10

The Holy Spirit draws people to God. One who blasphemes the Holy Spirit rejects his testimony about Jesus and so rejects God. This is the

unpardonable sin (see study notes on Matt 12:31–32).

Luke 12:11–12

brought to trial: Jesus predicted persecution from Jews in the synagogues and from Gentile rulers and authorities. Paul and other apostles faced both kinds of persecution throughout Acts.

Luke 12:13

tell my brother to divide our father's estate: In Judaism, the oldest son received a double portion of the inheritance ([Deut 21:17](#)) and was responsible for dividing up the rest after his father's death. This younger brother wanted his share of the estate (cp. [Luke 15:11–32](#)).

Luke 12:13–21

This parable shows the danger of trusting in riches instead of in God.

Luke 12:15

Guard against every kind of greed: See [Exod 20:17](#); [Deut 5:21](#); [Job 31:24–25](#); [Ps 49](#); [Eccl 2:1–11](#).

Luke 12:16–20

On the surface, the rich man had a perfectly prudent plan, but the constant focus was on himself (cp. [Eccl 5:10](#)); he never considered giving crops to the needy. He assumed that his riches would last and only wanted a place to store them, without bringing God into the equation at all ([Jas 4:13–17](#)). His judgment was just.

Luke 12:19–20

My friend: Literally *Soul*. The man was speaking to himself. • You fool! In Scripture, a fool is not someone with a low intelligence, but one who dishonors and disobeys God ([Ps 14:1–5](#)). • You will die (literally *Your soul will be demanded from you*):

The man was satisfied with his soul, but God was not.

Luke 12:22-34

Jesus' warning against greed ([12:13-21](#)) is followed by teaching about living in dependence on God. Jesus' disciples were to focus on God's Kingdom and his purpose in this world rather than being obsessed with possessions.

Luke 12:24

Look at the ravens: Ravens were unclean ([Lev 11:15](#); [Deut 14:14](#)), yet God cared even for them ([Ps 147:9](#)).

Luke 12:25

add a single moment to your life (literally *add a single cubit to his length*): Worry cannot add even one step on the road of life.

Luke 12:27

Solomon was among the richest kings of the world in his day (see [2 Chr 9:13-22](#)).

Luke 12:30

unbelievers: Greek *ethnē*, sometimes translated "the nations" or "the Gentiles." To a Jewish audience, it meant all who were not God's people.

Luke 12:31

Seek the Kingdom of God: Adopt God's value system, pursue his purpose in the world, and submit to his authority.

Luke 12:32

little flock: God is the shepherd of his people ([Ps 23](#); [Jer 13:17](#); [Ezek 34](#); [Zech 10:3](#)). Israel's leaders were also identified as shepherds and were criticized for

harming or neglecting their sheep ([Ezek 34](#); [Zech 10:3](#)).

Luke 12:33

Sell your possessions and give to those in need: This is not a command to liquidate all personal possessions, since elsewhere in the Bible it is assumed that believers will own property. It means recognizing that everything we have is God's and should be used to serve him and his people (see [Acts 2:44-45](#); [4:32-34](#)). Believers are responsible for meeting the needs of the poor, especially in the church ([Gal 6:10](#)). • treasure for you in heaven: See [Luke 16:1-13](#); [Matt 6:19-21](#). When God gives wealth, he also gives a ministry to help the unfortunate.

Luke 12:35

keep your lamps burning: This is a picture of readiness and vigilance ([Exod 27:20-21](#); [Lev 24:2](#); [Ps 18:28](#); [Matt 25:1-13](#)).

Luke 12:35-48

Jesus compared his faithful followers to servants in a master's household who were always prepared for his return and faithfully managed the resources he had left with them.

Luke 12:36

The master could return from the wedding feast at any time of day or night. Jesus' followers must always be faithful and prepared for his return.

Luke 12:37

he himself will seat them: In Middle Eastern culture, the master would never serve his servants! Jesus redefined the role of the master by serving his disciples, giving himself for them, and meeting all their needs (see [22:24-27](#)). • An apron was typical garb for a servant.

Luke 12:40

the Son of Man will come: See “The Son of Man” Theme Note.

Luke 12:42

The faithful, sensible servant was a household manager. Wealthy homeowners appointed gifted and educated slaves as chief executive officers over their affairs.

Luke 12:44

in charge of all he owns: Although servants in the Roman world were slaves (the master’s property), they could rise to very high social status, owning property, managing the entire household, and acting with the master’s authority.

Luke 12:46

he will cut the servant in pieces: Such brutal judgment was common in the ancient world. It is uncertain whether Jesus was talking about temporal punishment or eternal damnation. • and banish him with the unfaithful: This could either mean “treat him as an unbeliever” (a temporal judgment) or “send him to hell” (an eternal judgment), depending on whether Jesus was referring to discipline for a believer or condemnation of an unbeliever. The point is that an unfaithful servant faces stringent judgment.

Luke 12:47-48

who knows . . . who does not know: Sins of ignorance receive less punishment than intentional sins ([Num 15:22-26](#); [Ps 19:13](#); cp. [Luke 23:34](#)). • When someone has been given much: Believers will be held responsible for the knowledge and resources they have been given (see [Jas 3:1](#)). A sin in ignorance is still a sin.

Luke 12:49

I have come to set the world on fire: Jesus’ ministry radically changed the status quo, bringing judgment on the wicked and purifying the

righteous (see [3:16-17](#); [9:54](#); [17:29](#); [Deut 4:24](#); [Amos 5:6](#); [Heb 12:29](#)).

Luke 12:50

a terrible baptism of suffering: God’s judgment is often pictured as an overwhelming flood ([Pss 18:4; 42:7; 69:1-2](#); [Isa 8:7-8](#); [30:27-28](#); [Jon 2:5](#)).

Luke 12:51-53

I have come to divide people: Jesus’ ministry demands a decision for or against God that divides even family members.

Luke 12:53

Jesus quotes [Mic 7:6](#), which was interpreted by the rabbis as the crisis and persecution that would lead to the Messiah’s coming.

Luke 12:54

Clouds beginning to form in the west brought rain from the Mediterranean Sea.

Luke 12:55

The hot south wind blows into Israel from the Arabian Desert to the south and east ([Job 37:17](#); [Jer 4:11](#)).

Luke 12:58

on the way to court: This lawsuit over an unpaid debt would result in debtor’s prison. The officer is the bailiff of the court or the warden of the prison. It is advisable to negotiate accounts with your accuser, if possible, before reaching the courtroom. It is also best to reckon with God before the final day of judgment.

Luke 13:1

Pilate had murdered some people from Galilee: This particular incident is not known from other

sources, but Pilate was a ruthless governor who, on several occasions, violently suppressed revolts (see Josephus, *War* 2.9.2-4; *Antiquities* 18.3.1-2).

Luke 13:1-4

Jesus was responding to a popular claim that bad things only happen to bad people. Sin has negative consequences, but not every bad thing is a result of sin. Jesus then clarified that all people are sinners who need to repent ([13:3](#), [5](#); see [Job 4:7](#); [8:4](#), [20](#); [22:5](#); see also [Pss 34:21](#); [75:10](#); [Prov 3:33](#); [10:3](#), [6-7](#), [16](#), [24-25](#); [John 9:2-3](#)).

Luke 13:4

when the tower in Siloam fell: This incident is also unknown apart from this reference. The pool of Siloam was a reservoir in the southeastern corner of Jerusalem, so the tower might have been part of the southern wall of Jerusalem.

Luke 13:6

a fig tree: Israel was sometimes portrayed as an unfruitful fig tree or a vineyard that God would judge ([Isa 5:1-7](#); [Mic 7:1-2](#); see [Jer 8:13](#); [24:1-10](#); [Hos 9:10](#)).

Luke 13:6-9

The parable of the barren fig tree illustrated Jesus' ministry to Israel. Unless the nation produced the fruit of repentance, it would face judgment. The parable is open-ended—Israel was being offered the chance to respond. Cp. [Matt 21:18-19](#) // [Mark 11:12-14](#).

Luke 13:9

cut it down: A stump or fallen tree was an image of judgment or destruction (cp. [3:9](#); see also [Isa 6:13](#); [10:34](#); [11:1](#); [Jer 46:22](#); [Dan 4:23](#); [Matt 3:10](#); [7:19](#)).

Luke 13:10

as Jesus was teaching in a synagogue (see [4:14-30](#)): In the synagogue, visiting rabbis were often asked to teach after the Law and the Prophets were read.

Luke 13:11

crippled by an evil spirit: See study note on [11:14](#).

Luke 13:14

not on the Sabbath: Rabbis debated whether to give medical help on the Sabbath and decided it was acceptable only in cases of extreme emergency.

Luke 13:15-16

You hypocrites! The religious leaders would take care of their own animals on the Sabbath (to protect their investment) but then refuse to meet the needs of a fellow human being. In an ironic wordplay, the same word is translated untie ([13:15](#)) and released ([13:16](#)). The religious leaders would free their animals but not a daughter of Abraham—one of God's chosen people and a recipient of his favor. • in bondage by Satan: Jesus' exorcisms and healings manifested the Kingdom of God and the defeat of Satan (see [11:20](#)).

Luke 13:17

Jesus' skillful argument shamed and silenced his enemies. Honor was among the most important values in Jewish society.

Luke 13:18-21

The parables of the mustard seed and the yeast reveal the nature of the Kingdom of God. Like a mustard seed, it grows from a tiny size until it becomes large; like yeast leavening dough, it permeates the entire world.

Luke 13:19

the birds make nests: The birds represent people who find the Kingdom to be a place of protection and security.

Luke 13:21

It is like the yeast: Leaven can represent evil (see [12:1](#); [1 Cor 5:6](#); [Gal 5:9](#)), but here it is a positive image of the permeating, transforming power of the Kingdom.

Luke 13:23

will only a few be saved? Some believed that only a small number would be saved. Others thought that all Jews would be saved because they were descendants of Abraham (see study note on 3:8).

Luke 13:25

When the master of the house has locked the door: At a banquet, the master of the household locked the door after the invited guests had arrived. • I don't know you: In Scripture, *knowing* often means being chosen by God for a special relationship ([Isa 63:16](#); [Jer 1:5](#); [Amos 3:2](#)). The people of Israel were God's chosen people who had descended from Abraham (where you come from), but those who failed to respond to the invitation did not have a relationship with God. The same can be said of all who fail to respond to the Good News of the Kingdom.

Luke 13:28

The expression weeping and gnashing of teeth portrays rejection and suffering. • Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob were the three great founding patriarchs of the nation of Israel.

Luke 13:29

While many of God's chosen people, the Israelites, have rejected the gospel, other people . . . from all over the world will respond to God's offer of salvation and attend the messianic banquet (see

[14:15](#); [17:20](#); [Isa 2:2](#); [25:6-8](#); [51:4](#); [52:10](#); [55:5](#); [56:7](#); [59:19](#); [Mic 4:1-2](#); [Zech 2:13](#); [Mal 1:11](#)).

Luke 13:32

Go tell that fox: Among first-century Jews, foxes were viewed as destructive and worthless pests. • casting out demons and healing people: Jesus' exorcisms and healings were evidence that God's Kingdom was present; his resurrection on the third day would vindicate him and prove that he inaugurated God's Kingdom.

Luke 13:33

a prophet of God to be killed: See "The Suffering Prophet" Theme Note.

Luke 13:34

as a hen protects her chicks: Cp. [Deut 32:11](#); [Ruth 2:12](#); [Pss 17:8](#); [36:7](#); [57:1](#); [61:4](#); [63:7](#); [91:4](#).

Luke 13:35

your house is abandoned: Jesus predicted the destruction of Jerusalem that took place in AD 70. • Blessings on the one who comes in the name of the Lord! This refers to [Ps 118:26](#). [Psalm 118](#) was one of the psalms sung by pilgrims going up to Jerusalem for the annual festivals. Here Jesus referred to his second coming.

Luke 14:1

in the home of a leader of the Pharisees: In the Gospel of Luke, Jesus is frequently seen dining.

Luke 14:2

whose arms and legs were swollen (or *who had dropsy*): Dropsy, medically known as edema, is an accumulation of fluid in tissues or a body cavity that causes swelling. It is usually a symptom of a more serious illness.

Luke 14:3

Is it permitted in the law to heal people on the Sabbath day? This question was debated by the rabbis (see study note on 6:6–7).

Luke 14:5

Jesus pointed out the Pharisees' hypocrisy. See also study note on 13:15–16.

Luke 14:7

the seats of honor: Meals in the ancient world were rituals of social status. The place given to someone at the table was determined by their place in the social pecking order. The quality of the food served to each guest also depended on their status. These guests were jockeying for the places of highest honor.

Luke 14:8

Jesus' response was a commentary on [Prov 25:6–7](#).

Luke 14:9

Then you will be embarrassed: Honor was among the most important values in first century Jewish culture. This kind of humiliation would have been almost worse than death.

Luke 14:12–13

don't invite your friends: Jesus challenged the prevailing use of banquets to flaunt and elevate one's status in the community. The host would invite friends of equal status and a few who were higher. These honored guests would then be expected to reciprocate, raising the first host's social position and reputation. Jesus turned this hierarchy upside down by instructing his followers to invite those who had no social status and could not reciprocate. God invites sinful human beings to dine at his banquet table of salvation.

Luke 14:14

the resurrection of the righteous: see [Dan 12:2](#).

Luke 14:15–24

This parable portrays what was happening in Jesus' ministry. The rich, powerful, and elite rejected Jesus' invitation to God's salvation banquet and would be shut out. Meanwhile, poor people and outcasts responded to the invitation (see also [1:52–53](#); [6:21, 25](#); [10:15](#); [18:14](#)).

Luke 14:17

Come, the banquet is ready: The invitations would have been sent much earlier; the guests were summoned when the meal was ready.

Luke 14:18

they all began making excuses: All such excuses would have been a great affront to the host, who had made a great investment in this important social event. These guests had previously accepted the invitation, and all of their excuses were weak. Clearly, they just didn't want to attend the banquet.

- I have just bought a field and must inspect it: No one would buy a field without first inspecting it.

Luke 14:19

oxen, and I want to try them out: This is another weak excuse—no one would buy oxen without having seen them plow.

Luke 14:20

I just got married: Some see this as a legitimate excuse since the Old Testament exempted men from military service in their first year of marriage ([Deut 20:7](#); [24:5](#)), but this feast was a local community event, not a distant war. Furthermore, in an Israelite village, a marriage and a banquet would never be planned at the same time, so there was no real conflict.

Luke 14:21

The poor, the crippled, the blind, and the lame were the outcasts of Israel, to whom Jesus ministered.

Luke 14:23

Go out into the country lanes: These invitees might be a reference to the Gentiles to whom the Good News eventually went (cp. [Acts 9:15](#); [13:46-48](#); [18:4-6](#); [Rom 11:11-12](#)).

Luke 14:25-35

A large crowd was following Jesus: Jesus' popularity was high, but he was about to teach that the cost of following him was also very high.

Luke 14:26

you must, by comparison, hate everyone else: Following Jesus requires complete dedication. The phrase by comparison does not appear in the Greek, but it accurately represents Jesus' meaning. Love for family and one's own life must not compete with devotion to Christ.

Luke 14:27

To carry your own cross is a picture of dying to self. The horizontal beam of the cross was carried by a condemned criminal headed for crucifixion.

Luke 14:34

Salt . . . if it loses its flavor: Sodium chloride cannot actually lose its saltiness. Jesus might be speaking hypothetically (if salt were to lose), or he might be referring to a combination of minerals that included salt. The salt around the Dead Sea was a mixture of sodium chloride and other minerals. When the sodium chloride was removed, what was left behind was "salt" without saltiness.

Luke 14:35

good neither for the soil nor for the manure pile: Salt had various uses in the ancient world,

including flavoring ([14:34](#)), preserving, and weed-killing. The sludge left after removing the sodium chloride was useless.

Luke 15:1

Tax collectors were despised because they worked for the hated Roman authorities and were notorious for their corruption.

Luke 15:1-32

Chapter 15 contains three related parables of things lost and found: a sheep ([15:1-7](#)), a coin ([15:8-10](#)), and a son ([15:11-32](#)). The loss of something loved causes deep sorrow, whereas finding it brings great joy. There is great rejoicing in heaven when lost sinners return to their heavenly Father.

Luke 15:2

In their self-righteous hard-heartedness, the Pharisees and teachers of religious law did not care about lost people. Jesus embodied the heart of God, who longs for his wayward children to return.

Luke 15:4

A flock of a hundred sheep was of average size for a shepherd of modest means. God's people are often identified as the Lord's flock ([Ps 23](#); [Isa 53:6](#); [Jer 13:17](#); [Ezek 34](#); [Zech 10:3](#)). • leave the ninety-nine others: Other shepherds could watch the ninety-nine, so those left behind were not in danger. The shepherd would do anything to find the one that was lost.

Luke 15:8

ten silver coins: These coins might have been part of the woman's dowry. • light a lamp and sweep the entire house: Palestinian homes were poorly lit and normally had dirt or stone floors. Finding a small coin could be difficult.

Luke 15:11-32

Like the previous two parables ([15:3-7](#), [8-10](#)), the parable of the lost son demonstrates God's love for the lost and the joy he experiences when they return. It also allegorizes Jesus' ministry. The father represents God, the younger brother represents the tax collectors and sinners to whom Jesus ministered, and the older brother represents the religious leaders.

Luke 15:12

I want my share of your estate now: This appalling request essentially says, "To me, you are dead." There could be no greater insult to a father.

Luke 15:13

he wasted all his money in wild living: Jews considered the loss of family property to Gentiles in a distant land to be particularly disgraceful and grounds for excommunication (see also [Deut 21:18-21](#)).

Luke 15:15

Pigs were unclean animals ([Lev 11:7](#); [Deut 14:8](#)), making this the most degrading job imaginable for a Jew.

Luke 15:20

- *his father saw him*: The father was watching the road, hoping his son would return.
- *He ran to his son*: Since running was not appropriate for the leader of the family, this expressed how happy the father was that his son came back.

Luke 15:21

The son gave his rehearsed speech. Some manuscripts add *Please take me on as a hired servant*. The lack of this sentence in the better

manuscripts suggests that his father didn't give him a chance to finish.

Luke 15:22

The finest robe belonged to the father; it affirmed the son's role as an heir and a cherished member of the household. • Get a ring for his finger: A ring was a symbol of authority. Like the robe, it indicated his status as son and heir.

Luke 15:23

The father would have been fattening a calf for a banquet. The son was welcomed as a visiting dignitary.

Luke 15:28

The older brother was angry that his father would forgive such a sinner when he, the faithful son, had worked hard to achieve his position. Like the religious leaders, he refused to rejoice when his brother was found.

Luke 15:30

this son of yours: He refused to acknowledge his own relationship to his brother.

Luke 15:31

you have always stayed by me: The parable is open-ended: it does not record the older brother's response. The religious leaders still had a chance to respond to Jesus' offer of the Kingdom.

Luke 16:1

a certain rich man who had a manager: Wealthy landowners commonly put managers over their estates.

Luke 16:2

Get your report in order: This financial statement was probably for the benefit of the manager's successor.

Luke 16:3

I'm too proud to beg: The Jewish wisdom writer Sirach said, "It is better to die than to beg" (*Sirach* 40:28), a reflection of Jewish attitudes.

Luke 16:5-7

The manager called in his master's debtors and reduced their debts, thus making friends who would help him during his unemployment.

Luke 16:6

800 gallons . . . 400 gallons: The size of the bath—a standard liquid measure—is not known with certainty.

Luke 16:7

1,000 bushels . . . 800 bushels: The size of the cor—a standard dry measure—is not known with certainty.

Luke 16:8

The ways of the world are the opposite of God's ways. The children of this world use all their resources to get ahead in this world. God's people do just the opposite ([16:9](#)). • The children of the light are the people of God (see [John 12:36](#); [1 Thes 5:5](#)).

Luke 16:8-9

Jesus seems to commend the manager's dishonesty, but Jesus' point is that believers need to use resources shrewdly in preparation for eternity.

Luke 16:9

worldly resources: This is a better translation than the traditional "mammon of unrighteousness" (KJV). Believers are to use their resources wisely for spiritual benefit. • they will welcome you to an eternal home: *They* are probably the friends. Just as the manager's friends would give him security, the friends we win to the Kingdom will warmly welcome us for eternity.

Luke 16:13

No one can serve two masters: Complete love and devotion can be given only to one master.

Luke 16:14

The Pharisees . . . heard all this and scoffed: Wealth was commonly believed to be a reward from God, so the Pharisees derided Jesus' warning against riches.

Luke 16:16

John the Baptist was a transitional figure—the last in the line of Old Testament prophets and the herald of the age of salvation (see [1:5-25](#), [57-80](#); [3:1-20](#); [7:18-35](#)). • everyone is eager to get in: The verb normally means "to suffer violence" and may have the negative sense of violent force into or against the Kingdom (see [Matt 11:12](#)). More likely, it carries here a positive sense of urgency to enter the Kingdom.

Luke 16:17

that doesn't mean that the law has lost its force: Although the new covenant fulfilled the Old Testament law and prophets, the law has not passed away (however, cp. [Acts 15:23-29](#)). • Heaven and earth will be destroyed and replaced by a new heaven and earth at the end of the age ([Rev 21:1](#)), but God's word endures forever ([Ps 119:89](#), [160](#); [Isa 40:8](#); [55:10-11](#)).

Luke 16:18

This example fits the context by showing that Jesus' authoritative words interpreted and fulfilled the Old Testament law. • a man who divorces his wife and marries someone else commits adultery: The Old Testament allowed for divorce but did not sanction it ([Deut 24:1-4](#)), and the rabbis of Jesus' day debated what constituted legitimate grounds. The school of Shammai allowed a man to divorce his wife only because of unfaithfulness, while the school of Hillel allowed divorce for almost any reason. Against such a casual attitude, Jesus said that breaking the marriage vow by divorce and marrying someone else was equivalent to adultery. Elsewhere ([Matt 5:32](#); [19:9](#)), Jesus provided a clear exception for cases of unfaithfulness.

Luke 16:19

Purple was the color of royalty; Phoenician purple was an expensive dye made from mollusks.

Luke 16:19-31

This parable reiterates the theme of the danger of riches introduced in [16:13-15](#) and returns to the idea that the coming of God's Kingdom will mean the reversal of fortunes. The rich, proud, and powerful will be humbled and brought low, while the poor, humble, and oppressed will be exalted.

Luke 16:21

the dogs would come and lick his open sores: This is an image of misery and poverty. In Jewish culture, dogs were detestable, unclean scavengers.

Luke 16:22

carried by the angels to sit beside Abraham (literally *into Abraham's bosom*): The Greek suggests a banquet at which guests reclined around a low table (see [John 13:23](#)). Lazarus was taken to the messianic banquet in the Kingdom of God (see [Luke 14:1-24](#)).

Luke 16:23

The place of the dead (Greek *Hades*) can refer to the grave (death) generally, or to the place where the wicked go after death, as here.

Luke 16:24

I am in anguish in these flames: See [Matt 25:41](#); [Rev 20:10](#), [14-15](#). • Send Lazarus: Ironically, the man was still treating Lazarus as a lowly servant.

Luke 16:26

No one can cross over to you from here: A person's state after death is permanent.

Luke 16:31

they won't be persuaded even if someone rises from the dead: Wicked people refuse to repent even when faced with overwhelming evidence of the truth.

Luke 17:1

what sorrow awaits: Traditionally rendered *woe!* (see study notes on 6:24-26; 11:42-52). • the person who does the tempting: Leaders bear a greater responsibility because they are accountable not only for themselves, but for those they lead (see [Jas 3:1](#)).

Luke 17:2

A millstone is a large round stone with a hole in its center, used to grind grain in a mill. A millstone could weigh hundreds of pounds.

Luke 17:4

Even if that person wrongs you seven times a day: *Seven* is not intended to convey an exact number, but means "many times" (see [Ps 119:164](#)). See [Matt 18:21-22](#).

Luke 17:6

A mustard seed was proverbial for something very small (see [13:19](#)). • you could say to this mulberry tree, ‘May you be uprooted’: Black mulberry trees can live for hundreds of years and have a vast root system, making them very difficult to uproot. • it would obey you: This is not a call to use faith for arbitrary miracles. God has unlimited power, and those who trust in him will see him use it.

Luke 17:7–10

In Greco-Roman culture, servants existed to serve their masters faithfully. Faith ([17:5–6](#)) entails obedient submission to Christ and his commands.

Luke 17:11

While Jesus was on his way to Jerusalem: see study note on 9:51–19:44.

Luke 17:11–19

This healing reveals Jesus’ compassion and power; in Luke, the blessings of salvation are joyfully received by many outside Israel.

Luke 17:12

ten men with leprosy stood at a distance: See study note on 5:12. Lepers were required to keep their distance and cry out, “Unclean!” ([Lev 13:45–46](#)).

Luke 17:14

Go show yourselves to the priests: [Leviticus 14:2–32](#) sets out guidelines for priests to use in diagnosing leprosy and pronouncing a leper clean (see study notes on Luke 5:12, 14). • as they went: To leave without yet being healed required faith, which Jesus was testing (cp. [2 Kgs 5:9–14](#)).

Luke 17:16

The one man who returned to thank Jesus was a Samaritan, a hated foreigner in the eyes of most Jews (see study note on 10:33).

Luke 17:19

Your faith has healed you (or *Your faith has saved you*): The Greek verb can refer to either physical or spiritual healing. Jesus’ physical healings illustrate the salvation that his Kingdom brings.

Luke 17:20–21

When will the Kingdom of God come? The common understanding among Jews was that the Messiah would establish God’s Kingdom in Jerusalem; he would defeat Israel’s enemies and bring in a period of peace, prosperity, justice, and righteousness (see [3:15](#); cp. [Acts 1:6](#)). The Pharisees were apparently challenging Jesus’ claim to be the Messiah because he was not defeating the Romans or establishing his Kingdom physically on earth. Jesus did not reject this future manifestation of the Kingdom (see [Luke 21:27](#); [Matt 24:30–31](#)) but pointed out that the Kingdom of God was being revealed to them through his ministry, though they were missing it. • The Kingdom of God can’t be detected by visible signs: Jewish apocalyptic literature of Jesus’ day looked for visible signs in the heavens to signal the coming of the Messiah’s kingdom. Jesus elsewhere affirmed that such signs would appear (see [Luke 17:24](#); [21:25](#); [Acts 2:19–20](#)), but the Pharisees were missing the manifestation of the Kingdom in Jesus’ immediate ministry (cp. [Luke 7:22](#)). • the Kingdom of God is already among you (or *is within you*, or *is in your grasp*): The Kingdom of God was already being revealed through Jesus’ words and actions. It is unlikely that Jesus would say, “The Kingdom of God is within you,” to those who were rejecting his message.

Luke 17:20–37

This is the first of two discourses in Luke’s Gospel on the coming of the Kingdom and the return of the Son of Man (see also ch [21](#)).

Luke 17:22

you will long to see the day when the Son of Man returns (or *you will long for even one day with the Son of Man*): The Greek says simply, *you will long to see the days of the Son of Man*, which may refer to

his time on earth with his disciples or to the time of his second coming.

Luke 17:23-24

People will tell you, 'Look, there is the Son of Man': False Messiahs have arisen throughout history, but expectations for the Messiah were particularly high in the first century, as a variety of figures claimed to be God's agents of deliverance (see [Acts 5:36-37; 21:38](#)). Jesus warned his disciples not to follow these imposters. • For as the lightning flashes: Lightning lights up the whole sky and is visible to everyone in the area. Similarly, when Jesus suddenly returns, it will be evident to everyone.

Luke 17:25

suffer terribly: Jesus would soon suffer crucifixion (see study note on 9:22).

Luke 17:26-29

in Noah's day . . . in the days of Lot: See [Gen 6-9](#) for Noah and [Gen 18:16-19:29](#) for Lot; both are stories of God's cataclysmic judgment against human wickedness.

Luke 17:32-33

Lot's wife turned into a pillar of salt when she looked longingly back at Sodom ([Gen 19:26](#)). She exemplifies those who cling to . . . life.

Luke 17:34-35

one will be taken, the other left: Some consider this separation to refer to the Rapture of the church, but the parallels drawn to God's judgment in the Flood and against Sodom ([17:26-29](#)), as well as the reference to vultures and a dead body ([17:37](#)), suggest that it occurs at the final judgment (see [Mal 3:18; Matt 25:32](#)).

Luke 17:37

so these signs indicate that the end is near: This clause, which does not appear explicitly in the Greek, explains the significance of the cryptic saying about the vulture.

Luke 18:1-8

The parable of the persistent widow follows naturally from Jesus' teaching about coming troubles ([17:20-37](#)). Believers can face trials and persevere through persistent prayer.

Luke 18:2

a judge . . . who neither feared God nor cared about people: The two most important attributes for a good judge are regard for justice (fear of God), and compassion for people (see [2 Chr 19:6-7](#)). This judge had neither.

Luke 18:3

A widow: God is concerned for widows, orphans, and foreigners—the most vulnerable members of ancient society—and has promised judgment against those who oppress them ([Exod 22:22; Deut 10:18; 24:17; 27:19; Ps 68:5; Isa 1:23; 10:2; Jer 22:3; Ezek 22:7; Amos 5:10-13; Zech 7:10; Mal 3:5](#)). • Give me justice: The woman was in the right in this dispute—she was not asking for special favors.

Luke 18:5

driving me crazy: This colorful Greek expression literally means "striking the eye" or "giving me a black eye," as in boxing. The sense is of wearing someone down through persistence.

Luke 18:7

Will not God bring about justice: If persistence resulted in justice from this unjust judge, how much more will God, who loves both people and justice, answer our prayers.

Luke 18:8

when the Son of Man returns: This is an allusion to [Dan 7:13-14](#). • how many will he find on the earth who have faith? The question is whether believers will remain faithful through the trials that will precede the coming of the Son of Man (see [Matt 24:10-12](#); [2 Thes 2:3](#); [1 Tim 4:1](#)).

Luke 18:9-14

The topic of prayer ([18:1-8](#)) leads into this parable about the right attitude for approaching God.

Luke 18:10

a despised tax collector: See study note on 3:12.

Luke 18:12

I fast twice a week, and I give you a tenth of my income: Fasting and tithing were signs of piety in Judaism. The law required fasting only once a year ([Lev 16:29-31](#)), but pious Jews in Jesus' day fasted twice a week (see also [Luke 5:33](#); [11:41-42](#)).

Luke 18:13

he beat his chest in sorrow: This action indicated deep mourning and repentance.

Luke 18:14

Jesus' conclusion that only the tax collector went home justified before God would have shocked Jesus' audience, who regarded Pharisees as righteous and tax collectors as wicked. • those who exalt themselves will be humbled: See [1:52-53](#); [6:21, 25](#); [10:15](#); [14:11](#); [16:19-31](#).

Luke 18:15-17

This incident illustrates [18:14](#). • they scolded the parents: In this cultural context, children had no social status (see study note on 9:48), so the disciples viewed them as an interruption to Jesus' important ministry.

Luke 18:17

receive the Kingdom of God like a child: Entrance into the Kingdom of God requires childlike faith and dependence on God.

Luke 18:18

The man was probably a religious leader (traditionally *ruler*), not a political ruler. • what should I do to inherit eternal life? This question was commonly discussed by the rabbis of Jesus' day (see [10:27](#)).

Luke 18:18-30

The story of the rich religious leader warns against trusting in riches rather than pledging complete allegiance to God.

Luke 18:19

Why do you call me good? The man was calling Jesus "good" as a general compliment, but only God is truly good. Jesus was challenging the man's understanding of goodness—true goodness requires moral perfection.

Luke 18:20

you know the commandments: Jesus cites the fifth through ninth of the Ten Commandments ([Exod 20:12-16](#); [Deut 5:16-20](#)), which pertain to relationships between human beings.

Luke 18:21

I've obeyed all these commandments: The man's claim to have kept all the commandments shows that he misunderstood the nature of true goodness.

Luke 18:22

The man's love of his riches revealed that he had not perfectly obeyed God; he did not love God or others in the way that God requires ([10:25-28](#)).

Love of riches is a form of idolatry ([Eph 5:5](#); [Col 3:5](#)).

Luke 18:24-25

How hard it is for the rich to enter the Kingdom of God! Though Scripture sometimes speaks of riches as a blessing from God ([2 Chr 1:11-12](#); [Pss 112:3; 128:2](#); [Prov 8:18](#); [Isa 61:6](#)), many passages warn against the danger of trusting riches instead of God ([Ps 62:10](#); [Prov 11:28](#); [Jer 9:23-24](#); [49:4-5](#)). • the eye of a needle: See study note on Mark 10:25. This is not merely difficult, but impossible. No one can be saved while trusting in riches. Salvation comes only by dependence on God ([Luke 18:27](#)).

Luke 18:27

The point of the whole episode is that salvation is impossible by human effort, but possible by the grace of God.

Luke 18:28-30

We've left our homes to follow you: In contrast to the rich ruler, Peter and the other disciples had given up everything to follow Jesus. Jesus affirmed that they would receive back far more than they had given up.

Luke 18:30

repaid many times over in this life: Their reward would not necessarily be physical, but they would enjoy the blessings that come from spiritual wholeness and a right relationship with God.

Luke 18:31

Jesus' death was in fulfillment of all the predictions of the prophets; it was God's plan ([24:25-26](#), [46](#); [Acts 2:23](#); [3:18](#); [4:28](#)). The primary prophecy about the suffering Messiah is [Isa 52:13-53:12](#). Luke also refers to [Ps 2](#) ([Acts 4:25-26](#)), [Ps 16](#) ([Acts 2:25-28](#)), [Ps 118:22](#) ([Luke 20:17](#)), and [Isa 50:4-9](#) ([Luke 18:32-33](#)).

Luke 18:31-34

This was Jesus' last prediction of his suffering and death before entering Jerusalem for his final week of ministry (see also [9:22](#), [44-45](#); [17:25](#)).

Luke 18:32-33

mocked. . . . They will flog him: See [Isa 50:6](#).

Luke 18:34

The significance of his words was hidden from them: Not until after the resurrection did the disciples grasp the saving significance of Jesus' death (see [9:45](#); [24:13-34](#)).

Luke 18:35

Jericho was located in an oasis in the Judean wilderness, eighteen miles (thirty kilometers) northeast of Jerusalem. At 820 feet (250 meters) below sea level, Jericho is the world's lowest city and one of the oldest.

Luke 18:35-43

This account again demonstrates Jesus' care for the poor and marginalized in Israel. It reminds the reader that Jesus is the Son of David, the Messiah ([18:38](#)), shortly before he enters Jerusalem as king ([19:28-44](#)).

Luke 18:38

Son of David is a title for the Messiah, a descendant of David who would reign on David's throne forever (see [1:32-33](#); [2 Sam 7:11-16](#); [Isa 9:6-7](#); [11:1-5](#); [Jer 23:5-6](#); [33:15-16](#); [Ezek 37:24-25](#)).

Luke 19:1-10

The story of Zacchaeus is a fitting climax to Jesus' ministry to the outcasts of Israel on his journey to Jerusalem ([9:51-19:44](#)). The final verse of the episode ([19:10](#)) is often viewed as the theme verse of Luke's Gospel.

Luke 19:2

The chief tax collector for a particular region leased from the Romans the right to collect taxes, and then oversaw subordinate tax collectors from whom he collected a commission. This situation allowed Zacchaeus to get very rich, and chief tax collectors were hated even more than their subordinates (see study note on 3:12).

Luke 19:4

climbed a sycamore-fig tree: This act was very undignified for a man of Zacchaeus' power and wealth; it shows his genuine spiritual interest in Jesus.

Luke 19:5

Zacchaeus! . . . I must be a guest: Jesus knew Zacchaeus' name and invited himself to Zacchaeus' home, emphasizing his divine authority and that this appointment was made by God.

Luke 19:7

the guest of a notorious sinner: As with Levi earlier ([5:27-32](#)), Jesus' willingness to associate with sinners drew criticism (see study note on 5:30).

Luke 19:8

I will give them back four times: Normal restitution for a wrong committed was to add twenty percent to the value of the goods lost ([Lev 5:16](#); [Num 5:7](#)), though the penalty for theft of an animal was four or five times its value ([Exod 22:1](#)). Zacchaeus apparently regarded his financial gains as theft and promised the required restitution.

Luke 19:9

this man has shown himself to be a true son of Abraham: Zacchaeus was a child of Abraham by descent (a Jew); now he demonstrated faith like Abraham's (see [Rom 4:11-12](#)).

Luke 19:10

to seek and save those who are lost: The Lord is a shepherd who seeks lost sheep (see [Ps 23:1](#); [Isa 53:6](#); [Jer 13:17](#); [Ezek 34](#); [Zech 10:3](#); [13:7](#)).

Luke 19:11-27

This parable has two main purposes: (1) to teach stewardship, the need to manage gifts and resources well while the king (Jesus) is away (cp. [Matt 25:14-30](#)); and (2) to correct the impression that the Kingdom of God would begin right away upon Jesus' entrance into Jerusalem. Most Jews of Jesus' day expected that when the Messiah came, God's Kingdom would be established physically on earth, with Jerusalem at its center (see [Isa 2:2-4](#); [35:1-10](#); [65:17-25](#); [Jer 30-31](#); [Ezek 37, 40-48](#); [Mic 4:1-5](#)).

Luke 19:12

A nobleman was called away to a distant empire to be crowned king: The account fits the situation of Judea as a client kingdom of the Roman Empire. After the death of a king, claimants to the throne would go to Rome to try to gain support. Like the nobleman, Jesus would first depart (to heaven) to receive his royal authority; he will later return to rule God's people and judge those who have opposed him (see [19:14, 27](#)).

Luke 19:14

his people hated him and sent a delegation: This happened to Archelaus, the son of Herod the Great, who violently put down protests after the death of his father. In response, the Jews sent a delegation to plead against his kingship before the Roman emperor.

Luke 19:17

you will be governor of ten cities as your reward: Because of the servant's faithfulness, the king gave him a major position in his kingdom. Similarly, those who are faithful to Jesus in this life will

receive greater responsibility here and great rewards in heaven.

Luke 19:23

deposit my money in the bank: Literally *put the money on the table*, which means to give it to moneylenders who would loan it out at interest.

Luke 19:26

even more will be given: Those who are faithful with a little will be entrusted with more (cp. [8:18](#)).

Luke 19:27

as for these enemies of mine: Those who reject Jesus' reign as king will suffer his judgment. This part of the parable was directed against the religious leaders. • bring them in and execute them: A new king would often execute his opponents (see [1 Kgs 2:13-46](#); cp. [Ps 2](#)).

Luke 19:28-40

Jesus' triumphant entry into Jerusalem fulfilled [Zech 9:9-10](#) and symbolically announced that he was the Messiah, the King of Israel.

Luke 19:29

Bethany was on the eastern slope of the Mount of Olives, two miles east of Jerusalem; it was the home of Lazarus and his sisters, Mary and Martha ([John 11:1, 18; 12:1](#); see [Luke 10:38](#)). The location of Bethphage is uncertain, but it was probably near Bethany on the same road from Jericho. • The Mount of Olives overlooks Jerusalem from the east and has significance at the return of Christ (see [Acts 1:11; Zech 14:4](#)).

Luke 19:30

you will see a young donkey: It is unclear whether Jesus had arranged for the donkey ahead of time, or whether he used divine insight. Either way, Jesus' entrance into Jerusalem was a symbolic action. He

rode a humble *donkey* rather than a war horse to confirm that he was fulfilling the role of the Messiah by bringing reconciliation and peace ([Zech 9:9-10](#)).

Luke 19:31

The Lord needs it: Subjects of a king were expected to make resources available for his use (see [1 Sam 8:16](#)). The donkey's colt had never been ridden, so it was pure and suitable for a king.

Luke 19:36

The crowds spread out their garments to show honor and homage to this royal figure (see [2 Kgs 9:13](#)).

Luke 19:38

Blessings on the King . . . glory in highest heaven! See [Pss 118:26; 148:1](#). [Psalm 118](#) was one of the psalms sung by pilgrims traveling to Jerusalem for one of the festivals ([Pss 113-118](#)). • Jesus brought peace in heaven—reconciliation between God and human beings—but peace on earth awaits the future (cp. [Luke 2:14](#); see [12:51-53; 19:41-44](#)).

Luke 19:40

Compare [Isa 55:12](#), in which nature is said to rejoice at the coming of God's salvation, and [Hab 2:11](#), in which the stones of the walls cry out against Babylon.

Luke 19:42

now it is too late: Israel's rejection of Jesus was irrevocable.

Luke 19:43-44

Jesus foretold the siege and destruction of Jerusalem by the Romans in AD 70. The Jewish historian Josephus describes the horrific suffering of the inhabitants of Jerusalem during the Roman

siege (*War* 5.1.1–7.1.1). • will not leave a single stone in place: This is an image of total devastation.

Luke 19:45

Pilgrims coming to worship at the Temple would purchase animals for sacrifices in the Temple courts. Jesus also drove out the money changers who provided the correct currency for the Temple tax ([Matt 21:12](#); [Mark 11:15](#); see [Exod 30:13–16](#); [Neh 10:32–33](#)). While these were necessary services, Jesus objected to the exploitation of the Temple for illicit commercial gain that distracted from its purpose as a place of worship. The Temple was meant to reflect God's glory for all nations, but it had become corrupt.

Luke 19:45–48

Having just entered Jerusalem as the Messiah, Jesus performed a messianic action (cp. [Mal 3:1](#)) by driving money changers and merchants selling animals for sacrifices out of the Temple. This cleansing was to restore true worship to the Temple. It was also symbolic of the judgment that Jesus had just pronounced against Israel ([19:41–44](#)).

Luke 19:47

The clearing of the Temple catalyzed the opposition and precipitated Jesus' crucifixion (but see study note on Mark 11:12–25). • Jesus' opposition in Galilee came mainly from the Pharisees and teachers of religious law; in Jerusalem, the opposition also included the leading priests, who controlled the Temple. Jesus' actions against the Temple trade threatened their authority.

Luke 20:1

the leading priests, the teachers of religious law, and the elders: The most influential Jewish leaders in Jerusalem converged against Jesus, who threatened their authority.

Luke 20:1–47

In this series of controversies between Jesus and the religious leaders of Jerusalem, they repeatedly questioned and challenged him, and he repeatedly outmatched them with his spiritual wisdom, insight, and authority.

Luke 20:2

By what authority are you doing all these things? Since these groups were the recognized Jewish authorities in Jerusalem, they wanted to know how Jesus could claim authority to enter Jerusalem as a king and drive the merchants from the Temple.

Luke 20:4–6

Jesus' question put the religious leaders in a double bind (see [20:5–6](#)), as either answer would indict them.

Luke 20:6

the people will stone us: Stoning was the penalty for blasphemy ([Lev 24:14–15](#)), idolatry ([Lev 20:2](#); [Deut 13:10](#)), and other sins of defiance against God. The people might have regarded rejection of an authentic prophet as blasphemy deserving of stoning.

Luke 20:7–8

The Jewish authorities refused to answer Jesus' question, so Jesus had no obligation to answer their question. Both their question and their refusal were guided by self-interest rather than integrity.

Luke 20:9

leased it to tenant farmers: This was a common practice in first-century Palestine, especially in Galilee, where peasants would lease the right to raise crops from wealthy landowners.

Luke 20:9–19

This story adapts Isaiah's Song of the Fruitful Vineyard ([Isa 5:1–7](#)) to allegorize Jesus' rejection by Israel's leaders. In Isaiah's allegory, the vineyard owner is God and Israel is the unfruitful vineyard that will be judged. Jesus added new characters—the tenant farmers were Israel's unrighteous leaders, the servants were the Old Testament prophets (repeatedly rejected by Israel), and the son was Jesus. God would judge Israel's leaders for rejecting and murdering his son.

Luke 20:10

the farmers attacked the servant: God's prophets were often mistreated and opposed ([1 Kgs 19:10, 14](#); [2 Chr 24:21](#); [36:16](#); [Neh 9:26](#); [Jer 2:30](#); [26:20–24](#); [37:15](#)).

Luke 20:13

my cherished son: The Messiah was predicted to have a unique father-son relationship with God (see [2 Sam 7:14](#); [Pss 2:7](#); [89:26–29](#)).

Luke 20:14

Let's kill him and get the estate for ourselves! They believed that killing the heir would give them power over the estate. They foolishly failed to realize that the owner was still alive and would demand justice. Similarly, the religious leaders thought that they could keep their authority over the people of Israel by killing Jesus.

Luke 20:17

The stone . . . cornerstone: Jesus cited [Ps 118:22](#) to predict his rejection and restoration. The cornerstone was the key part of a building, used to support and align adjoining walls. Jesus was rejected by the builders (the religious leaders), but he would become the foundation of a new building (the church).

Luke 20:18

Jesus expanded the stone metaphor ([20:17](#)) with allusions to [Isa 8:14–15](#) and [Dan 2:34, 44–45](#). Although Israel rejected him, Jesus was the foundation for the new people of God, and he inaugurated a Kingdom that would last forever.

Luke 20:19

they realized he was telling the story against them: The story provoked the religious leaders to act it out by arresting and killing Jesus.

Luke 20:20–26

The religious leaders' question was meant to trap Jesus, but he once again outwitted them.

Luke 20:21

we know that you speak and teach what is right: This flattery was meant to throw Jesus off guard (see [Pss 5:9](#); [12:2–3](#); [78:36](#); [Prov 26:28](#); [28:23](#); [29:5](#); [Ezek 12:24](#)).

Luke 20:22

is it right for us to pay taxes to Caesar or not? If Jesus said yes, he would make the people angry, because they hated the burden of Roman taxation. If he said no, he would be accused of rebellion against the Roman authorities.

Luke 20:24

a Roman coin: This coin had the picture and title of the emperor Tiberius Caesar (see [3:1](#)) stamped on it.

Luke 20:25

give to Caesar what belongs to Caesar: Jesus' brilliant answer could be taken in two ways. On the face of it, he said that this was Caesar's money that should properly be paid to Caesar. Jesus' Jewish listeners also knew that *what belongs to Caesar* was

actually nothing, since everything in the universe belongs to God.

Luke 20:27

Sadducees . . . who say there is no resurrection from the dead: See “The Sadducees” Profile.

Luke 20:28

Moses gave us a law: A dead man’s brother would marry the widow to produce children who would maintain the dead man’s name and property ([Deut 25:5-6](#); see also [Gen 38:8-10](#); [Ruth 4:1-12](#)).

Luke 20:29-33

Well, suppose there were seven brothers: A similar story of a woman married to seven husbands appears in the Old Testament Apocrypha (*Tobit* 3:7-17; 6:10-8:18).

Luke 20:33

whose wife will she be in the resurrection? The Sadducees used this hypothetical situation in an attempt to show that the idea of resurrection was absurd. This was probably a stock polemic that the Sadducees used in debating the Pharisees.

Luke 20:35

will neither marry nor be given in marriage: Jesus emphasized that marriage is an institution for this life, not for the resurrection.

Luke 20:36

In this respect they will be like angels: Angels are not married, and they are immortal. The Bible never teaches that people become angels (cp. [Heb 1:5-2:18](#)), but that we will be like them.

Luke 20:37

Having refuted the Sadducees’ argument about marriage, Jesus turned to the larger question concerning the resurrection. • even Moses proved this: Jesus used the books of Moses (Genesis—Deuteronomy)—the only Scripture the Sadducees recognized as authoritative—to prove the resurrection. • the God of Abraham . . . Jacob: God identified himself as the God of Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob long after these patriarchs had died. Since he was still their God, they must have had a continuing existence after death.

Luke 20:39

Well said, Teacher! Most teachers of religious law were Pharisees, so they agreed with Jesus on the resurrection and were pleased that he refuted the Sadducees.

Luke 20:40

Jesus’ wise answers confounded his opponents, thwarting their attempts to trap him.

Luke 20:41

The Old Testament predicted that the Messiah would be a descendant of David (see study note on 18:38).

Luke 20:41-44

Having silenced his opponents, Jesus took the offensive in challenging the religious leaders’ concept of the Messiah.

Luke 20:42-43

Jesus quotes [Ps 110:1](#), which indicates that the Messiah is David’s Lord.

Luke 20:44

Jesus asked why David addressed his son (i.e., his descendant) as his Lord. The implied answer was that the Messiah was more than just a human king

descended from David. He is Lord of all (see [2:11](#); [Acts 10:36](#)). [Psalm 110:1](#) became an important text for the apostles, confirming Jesus' identity as the Son of God (see [Mark 14:62](#); [Acts 2:34](#); [7:56](#); [Rom 8:34](#); [1 Cor 15:25](#); [Eph 1:20](#); [Col 3:1](#); [Heb 1:3, 13](#); [8:1](#); [10:12–13](#); [1 Pet 3:22](#); [Rev 3:21](#)).

Luke 20:46–47

Jesus continued on the offensive, warning against the hypocrisy and exploitation of the teachers of religious law. • respectful greetings . . . seats of honor: See study note on 11:43. • head table at banquets: See study notes on 5:30; 14:7.

Luke 20:47

Yet they shamelessly cheat widows: This might mean exploiting widows' property over which they were appointed guardians; it could also mean coercing widows to give money beyond their means. Widows were the most vulnerable members of society, and God had special concern for them. He would judge those who exploited them ([Exod 22:22](#); [Deut 10:18](#); [27:19](#)).

Luke 21:1

The Greek term translated collection box probably refers to the chests with trumpet-shaped openings used to collect offerings.

Luke 21:1–4

Jesus set the sacrificial offering of the poor widow in contrast to the greed and hypocrisy of the rich people, including the teachers of religious law ([20:45–47](#)).

Luke 21:2

two small coins: Together, two *lepta* were worth only about 1/64 of a denarius (the standard day's wage for a laborer).

Luke 21:4

The amount given counts for less than the heart attitude of the giver.

Luke 21:5

majestic stonework: Herod the Great rebuilt and restored the Jerusalem Temple, producing one of the great structures of the ancient world. According to Josephus, the massive white stones reflected the sun with such brilliance that from a distance the Temple looked like snow-covered mountains (*War* 5.5.6). • The memorial decorations were probably funded by offerings given by worshipers to fulfill vows.

Luke 21:5–38

When Jesus predicted the destruction of the Temple of Jerusalem ([21:6](#)), his disciples questioned when it would take place and what signs would accompany it ([21:7](#)). Jesus responded by describing the events surrounding the destruction of the Temple and the return of the Son of Man ([21:8–36](#)). This sermon is known as the Olivet Discourse because the Mount of Olives was the site of Jesus' teaching (see [Matt 24:3](#); [Mark 13:3](#)).

Luke 21:6

Not one stone will be left on top of another: See study note on 19:43–44.

Luke 21:8

claiming, 'I am the Messiah': See study note on Mark 13:5–6.

Luke 21:8–11

Jesus foretold events that are often misinterpreted as signs of the end, such as the appearance of false messiahs, wars, earthquakes, famines, and severe persecution, but Jesus said that the end won't follow immediately.

Luke 21:11

Cataclysmic events such as these are often associated with the judgment of God ([1 Sam 14:15](#); [Ps 18:7-8](#); [Isa 2:19, 21](#); [5:25](#); [13:13](#); [24:18](#); [29:5-6](#); [Jer 14:12](#); [21:6-7](#); [Ezek 14:21](#); [Amos 1:1](#)) and the end of the age ([Isa 24:18](#); [29:5-6](#); [Ezek 38:19](#); [Joel 2:10](#); [Hag 2:6, 21](#); [Zech 14:4](#); cp. [Rev 6:12](#); [8:5](#); [11:13, 19](#); [16:18](#)). • great miraculous signs from heaven: See study note on 21:25.

Luke 21:12

dragged into synagogues: Jesus and his early followers were Jewish, and the earliest conflicts were with fellow Jews who did not accept Jesus as the Messiah. Jesus' followers were sometimes tried in the synagogue before a Jewish tribunal (cp. [2 Cor 11:24](#)).

Luke 21:12-19

a time of great persecution: Jesus described the persecution that his followers would experience (see also [Matt 10:17-22](#); [Mark 13:9](#)). The Jewish literature of Jesus' day similarly described a time of great tribulation prior to the arrival of God's final salvation.

Luke 21:15

I will give you the right words: God often assured his prophets that he would give them the words to say ([Exod 4:12, 15](#); [Deut 18:18](#); [Isa 50:4](#); [51:16](#); [Jer 1:9](#)). Jesus' disciples were to prepare themselves to be clear witnesses (see [Col 4:5-6](#); [2 Tim 2:21](#); [1 Pet 3:15](#)), knowing that the Spirit would help them to respond as powerfully as Jesus had done ([Luke 20:20-44](#)).

Luke 21:16

Families in Jewish and Gentile communities have often been divided as some members follow Jesus and some reject him.

Luke 21:18-19

But not a hair of your head will perish! This idiom signifies full protection ([1 Sam 14:45](#); [2 Sam 14:11](#); [1 Kgs 1:52](#); [Dan 3:27](#)). It refers here to the disciples' souls, because some would be martyred for their faith ([Luke 21:16](#)).

Luke 21:20-24

Jesus was describing the siege and destruction of Jerusalem that would take place in AD 70.

Luke 21:21

Those in Jerusalem must get out: Because of this prophecy, Christians in Judea fled to the town of Pella in Decapolis before the destruction of Jerusalem in AD 70 (Eusebius, *Church History* 3.5).

Luke 21:22

For those will be days of God's vengeance: The destruction of Jerusalem was part of God's judgment for Israel's rejection of the Messiah.

Luke 21:24

until the period of the Gentiles comes to an end: Daniel predicted a period of successive Gentile empires before the coming of God's Kingdom ([Dan 2:44](#); [7:27](#)).

Luke 21:25

The prophets predicted that heavenly signs would precede the judgment of God at the end of the age ([Isa 13:9-10](#); [34:4](#); [Jer 4:23, 28](#); [Ezek 32:7-8](#); [Joel 2:10, 30-31](#); cp. [Rev 6:13-14](#); [8:10](#); [9:1](#); [12:1, 3](#); [15:1](#)).

Luke 21:31

All these things refers to the events described in [21:25-30](#).

Luke 21:32

this generation will not pass from the scene: This saying is puzzling—Jesus seems to have predicted that he would come again before the first generation of his disciples died out. There are three main interpretations: (1) the reference is to the destruction of Jerusalem in AD 70 when Jesus “came” in judgment against the nation of Israel; (2) “this generation” is not Jesus’ contemporaries, but a future generation alive when these signs begin coming to fulfillment; (3) the term *generation* could be translated “race,” referring to the Jewish race that will not disappear before Christ returns.

Luke 21:33

Heaven and earth will disappear: See study note on 16:17.

Luke 21:34

The central theme of the discourse is Watch out! Believers are always to be alert and ready for Christ’s return.

Luke 21:36

To stand before means “to pass the test” and stand approved before Jesus Christ at his second coming.

Luke 22:1

The Passover meal was held on the 15th of Nisan (March~April) in the Jewish calendar and was immediately followed by the seven-day Festival of Unleavened Bread ([Exod 12:1-20](#); [23:15](#); [34:18](#); [Deut 16:1-8](#)), sometimes also called Passover.

Luke 22:1-6

The religious leaders who had been plotting against Jesus (see [19:47](#)) found their opportunity when Judas Iscariot approached them with an offer to betray Jesus.

Luke 22:3

Satan entered into Judas Iscariot: See [John 13:2](#); [Acts 5:3](#). Satan had previously tempted Jesus ([Luke 4:2](#)) and had been waiting for this opportunity ([4:13](#)).

Luke 22:4

captains of the Temple guard: The Temple had its own police force.

Luke 22:5

Judas wanted the money. John tells us that he was a thief who stole from the disciples’ common fund ([John 12:6](#)).

Luke 22:6

when the crowds weren’t around: This was because of Jesus’ popularity among the people.

Luke 22:7

The Passover lamb was sacrificed at twilight, and Passover was celebrated in the evening (see [Exod 12:6-8](#)).

Luke 22:7-30

Jesus celebrated the traditional Jewish Passover but transformed it with reference to his own sacrificial death as the Passover lamb. He also prepared his disciples for his coming death and the leadership role they would assume over his church.

Luke 22:8

Go and prepare the Passover meal: The lamb was roasted and eaten with bitter herbs and unleavened bread at the Passover meal ([Exod 12:8](#); [Num 9:11-12](#); [Deut 16:3](#)). The bitter herbs represented the bitterness of the Israelites’ slavery in Egypt, and the unleavened bread recalled their haste in leaving Egypt.

Luke 22:10

A man carrying a pitcher of water would have been an unusual sight, because women normally carried the water.

Luke 22:11–12

The text does not say whether Jesus exhibited supernatural foreknowledge or whether he had made arrangements for this room ahead of time (see also [19:30–34](#)).

Luke 22:14

sat down together at the table (or *reclined together*): The Jewish people followed Hellenistic practice at banquets by reclining on couches (see study note on John 13:23).

Luke 22:15

Jesus ate the Passover meal with his disciples and followed the ritual order of the Passover celebration (see study note on Matt 26:26–29).

Luke 22:16

until its meaning is fulfilled in the Kingdom of God: This celebration had as its goal the messianic banquet (see [14:1–24](#)). Jesus' death as the true Passover lamb ([1 Cor 5:7](#)) inaugurated the Kingdom of God that will be completed at Jesus' second coming.

Luke 22:17

he took a cup of wine: The traditional Passover celebration used four cups of wine—at the opening benediction, after the Passover explanation, after the meal, and after a concluding psalm. This was probably the first cup that introduced the ceremony.

Luke 22:19–20

Using the bread and cup as symbols of his body and blood, Jesus instituted the communion service that

the disciples were to practice in remembrance of his death. • This is my body, which is given for you: The unleavened bread of the Passover symbolized Jesus' death as the Passover lamb. His death would pay for the sins of the world (cp. [1 Cor 11:24–25](#)).

Luke 22:20

God's covenants in the Old Testament were confirmed with the blood of a sacrifice ([Gen 15:9–10](#); [Exod 24:8](#)). Jesus' death established the new covenant that God had promised his people ([Jer 31:31–34](#)).

Luke 22:21–22

it has been determined: Though wicked men betrayed and killed Jesus, it was part of God's sovereign plan to accomplish salvation (see [Acts 2:23](#)).

Luke 22:22

what sorrow awaits the one who betrays him: Judas suffered guilt, condemnation, and a gruesome death for betraying Jesus ([Matt 27:5](#); [Acts 1:18](#)).

Luke 22:24

who would be the greatest among them: See also [Mark 9:33–37](#); [10:35–45](#).

Luke 22:25

friends of the people: This translates a Greek word that refers to the practice of rulers bestowing gifts and favors on their subjects to gain loyalty and honor. Jesus contrasted the world's leadership style—military power, coercion, and bribery—with his own servant leadership in sacrificing himself for others.

Luke 22:27

For I am among you as one who serves: Jesus defined true leadership as service—meeting the

needs of others and empowering them to be all that God has called them to be (see [Mark 10:45](#)). This statement was striking in a culture for which status and power were central.

Luke 22:29–30

I now grant you the right to eat and drink at my table: See “The Messianic Banquet” Theme Note.

Luke 22:30

you will sit on thrones, judging the twelve tribes of Israel: This could be a figurative reference to the apostles’ leadership in the church, or it could indicate their special role in the future when the Kingdom would be consummated on earth (cp. [Eph 2:20](#); [Rev 3:21](#); [20:4](#)).

Luke 22:31

Regarding Satan, see [4:2](#); [10:18](#); [11:15](#). Satan is the accuser of God’s people (see [Job 1:7](#); [2:2](#)); he would test Simon Peter and the rest of the apostles. • asked to sift: Wheat was sifted through a sieve to separate the grain from the chaff. It is an image of extreme testing (see [Isa 30:28](#); [Amos 9:9](#)). • The NLT’s each of you is precise, because the Greek *you* is plural, referring to all the disciples. Jesus foresaw Peter’s denial and the trials of the other disciples.

Luke 22:32

So when you have repented: This *you* is singular; it refers to Peter’s restoration after his denial of Jesus.

Luke 22:33

See [Acts 4:3](#); [5:18](#); [12:1–9](#), where Peter suffered trials and was repeatedly jailed. Church tradition relates that Peter was crucified in Rome, but his declaration of loyalty here was premature.

Luke 22:34

On Thursday evening, Jesus said that Peter would deny him before the rooster crows tomorrow morning (literally *before the rooster crows today*): This does not contradict Mark’s “this very night, before the rooster crows twice” ([Mark 14:30](#)); Luke and Matthew are simply more general, and in Jewish reckoning, sunset was the beginning of the next day.

Luke 22:36

take your money and a traveler’s bag: For their missions to Israel’s villages, the apostles had traveled without provisions and depended on others’ support ([9:3](#); [10:3–4](#)). In the dangerous days to come, they would have to plan more carefully. Jesus prepared his disciples for his suffering and death, and also for the establishing of the church and the worldwide proclamation of the Good News. • a sword: Jesus was probably not telling his followers to take up arms, but was speaking metaphorically—they must prepare themselves for a violent crisis.

Luke 22:38

That’s enough: The disciples’ two swords were probably not enough to defend the whole group, and Jesus elsewhere rejected violence ([22:49–51](#) // [Matt 26:52](#)). Jesus might have meant that two swords were sufficient to fulfill [Isa 53:12](#). Or perhaps he meant, “Enough of this foolish talk—you are misunderstanding me.”

Luke 22:39

Mount of Olives: See study note on 19:29. This was the location of the Garden of Gethsemane (see [Matt 26:36](#); [Mark 14:32](#)).

Luke 22:42

please take this cup of suffering away: A cup is a metaphor for experiencing either judgment or blessing (see, e.g., [Pss 23:5](#); [75:8](#); [116:13](#); [Isa 51:17](#)). Jesus felt all the emotions of his humanity, including fear and anxiety.

Luke 22:43

an angel from heaven: Angels often help and encourage human beings (see [Heb 1:14](#); cp. [1 Kgs 19:5-8](#); [Ps 91:11-12](#); [Dan 3:28](#); [10:16-19](#)).

Luke 22:44

his sweat fell to the ground like great drops of blood: The text does not say that Jesus sweated blood, as is often supposed, but that his sweat fell like blood pouring to the ground, which probably means that in his agony he sweated profusely.

Luke 22:45-46

Jesus' agonized prayer contrasted with the disciples' failure to be vigilant against temptation.

Luke 22:47

A kiss was a common greeting between friends. Judas's kiss highlighted his treachery.

Luke 22:51

he touched the man's ear and healed him: John tells us that the man's name was Malchus and that Peter was the one who cut off his ear ([John 18:10](#)). Peter probably thought that he was precipitating the final war and that the heavenly host was about to appear and destroy the Romans. When Jesus refused to fight, the terror-stricken disciples fled ([Matt 26:56](#) // [Mark 14:50](#)).

Luke 22:52

The Greek word translated revolutionary normally means "thief," but the Romans used this term for violent revolutionaries who opposed Roman authority (such as Barabbas, [23:18-19](#)). To patriotic Jews, they were freedom fighters; to the Romans, they were common thugs.

Luke 22:54

The high priest's home might have been the home of Caiaphas, the current high priest, or Annas, his

father-in-law and a previous high priest (see study note on 3:2; [John 18:12-14](#)).

Luke 22:59

because he is a Galilean: Peter's Galilean accent gave him away (cp. [Judg 12:5-6](#)).

Luke 22:61

the Lord turned and looked at Peter: Jesus was in the house being questioned and must have looked through a window or vestibule. When their eyes met and the rooster crowed, Peter remembered Jesus' prediction ([22:34](#)).

Luke 22:63

mocking and beating him: See [18:32](#); [Isa 50:6](#); [53:3-5](#).

Luke 22:64

Prophecy to us! Who hit you that time? Jesus had a reputation as a prophet ([4:24](#); [7:16](#), [39](#); [13:33](#); [24:19](#)), so the soldiers mocked this claim.

Luke 22:66

At daybreak: It was Friday morning (see study note on 22:34). • all the elders of the people assembled: The Jewish high council (Greek *Sanhedrin*) was originally made up of the Jerusalem nobility, both civil leaders and priests, with the high priest as its head. In Jesus' time, the Sadducees still controlled the Sanhedrin ([Acts 5:17](#)), though leading Pharisees had also gained a prominent place on the council ([Acts 23:7](#)).

Luke 22:67-68

If I tell you, you won't believe me: Jesus pointed out the hypocrisy of the question. They had already made up their minds that he was not the Messiah, so it would do no good to answer.

Luke 22:69

Jesus referred to [Ps 110:1](#) (cp. [Luke 20:42-43](#)). Though he would be crucified, Jesus would be vindicated through his resurrection and exalted to God's right hand (see [Acts 2:33-36](#); cp. [Dan 7:13-14](#)). Furthermore, he would be seated in the place of power as Judge. Jesus would soon sit in judgment over those who were trying him.

Luke 22:70

The significance of Jesus' statement ([22:69](#)) was not lost on the council members. The Messiah was expected to be the Son of God and have a special father-son relationship with God (see study notes on [1:32-33](#); [4:41](#); cp. [2 Sam 7:14](#); [Pss 2:7](#); [89:26](#)). The Sanhedrin accused Jesus of claiming to be the Messiah (cp. study notes on [Mark 14:62](#), [63-64](#)). • You say that I am: This is a qualified affirmation. Jesus probably meant, "What you say is true, but you do not understand what 'Messiah' means." They understood it as a confirmation ([Luke 22:71](#)).

Luke 22:71

Why do we need other witnesses? The high council regarded Jesus' confirmation that he was both the Messiah and the Son of God as a blasphemous claim and thus as proof of his guilt.

Luke 23:1

The council did not have the right to administer capital punishment ([John 18:31](#)), so they had to take Jesus before the Roman governor, who was in Jerusalem to maintain order during the potentially turbulent Passover festival.

Luke 23:2

The religious charges against Jesus were now replaced by political ones in order to gain a Roman conviction. Pilate was only interested in what concerned Rome. The Jewish charge of blasphemy would not be sufficient, so the council had to show that Jesus was a danger to Rome. They accused Jesus of inciting insurrection against Roman taxation and claiming to be a king. All but the last charge were false.

Luke 23:3

You have said it: This is the same vague answer that Jesus gave to the high council ([22:70](#)), emphasizing Jesus' acceptance of the title "king of the Jews" but suggesting that Pilate's understanding of the title was different from his own.

Luke 23:4

I find nothing wrong with this man! To Pilate, Jesus did not seem to be a political threat.

Luke 23:5

he is causing riots: This accusation was also false, but the religious leaders knew that Pilate feared civil unrest and revolt against Rome.

Luke 23:6-7

Realizing that Jesus was a Galilean and thus under the jurisdiction of Herod Antipas, Pilate saw an opportunity to get out of this sticky situation without condemning an innocent man or angering the religious leaders.

Luke 23:8

Herod was delighted: He was curious about Jesus' power as a miracle worker and religious teacher, just as he had been curious about John the Baptist ([9:7](#), [9](#); [Mark 6:20](#)).

Luke 23:9

Jesus refused to answer: See [Isa 53:7](#).

Luke 23:12

Herod and Pilate, who had been enemies before: There was a history of bad blood between Herod Antipas and Pilate. Herod and three of his brothers had previously brought charges against Pilate before Tiberius Caesar when Pilate set up idolatrous golden shields in Jerusalem, and

Tiberius had ordered Pilate to remove the shields. Pilate was also governing Judea, which Antipas's father, Herod the Great, had once ruled, and which Antipas hoped one day to claim as his own.

Luke 23:14–15

Pilate and Herod repeatedly declared Jesus innocent ([23:4](#), [22](#))—Jesus was the righteous and innocent suffering servant of the Lord (see also [23:41](#), [47](#); [Isa 53:11](#)).

Luke 23:16–18

I will have him flogged (or *I will teach him a lesson!*): The Greek word can mean “instruct,” “punish,” or “discipline”; it refers to a relatively mild whipping given for lesser offenses. It was different from the severe flogging that Romans gave in preparation for crucifixion (see [Matt 27:26](#); [Mark 15:15](#)).

Luke 23:19

Palestine was a breeding ground for insurrection in the decades leading up to the Jewish revolt of AD 66–74. The Jewish historian Josephus describes a series of first-century revolutionaries, such as Judas of Galilee, who opposed Roman rule and taxation (see also [Acts 5:36–37](#)).

Luke 23:24

So Pilate sentenced Jesus to die: Pilate, always the ruthless pragmatist, felt that it was worth a miscarriage of justice to avoid antagonizing the religious leaders and crowds and jeopardizing his political career (see [John 19:12](#) and corresponding study note).

Luke 23:26

Simon might have been a Jewish pilgrim visiting Jerusalem for Passover. • put the cross on him: Prisoners bound for crucifixion were normally forced to carry the crossbeam to the place of execution. It was fastened to the upright beam at the crucifixion site.

Luke 23:28

Jesus warned of the horrors that would come to Jerusalem during its siege and destruction in AD 70.

Luke 23:29

Fortunate indeed are the women who are childless: Childlessness was normally a cause of great shame (see study note on 1:7), but during this catastrophe, those who didn't have to see their children starve to death would be the fortunate ones.

Luke 23:30

‘they will say to the mountains, “Fall on us!”’: This refers to a time when people would prefer death over the terrible suffering they would face. Jesus warned that Jerusalem would experience such terrible pain and destruction that people would beg for mountains to fall on them to end their suffering quickly.

Luke 23:31

If the Romans crucified an innocent man when the tree was green (i.e., during a period of relative peace), what more horrible things would they do when it was dry (i.e., when the land had become a tinderbox of revolution)? During the siege of Jerusalem (AD 66–70), the Romans crucified thousands of Jews outside the city of Jerusalem.

Luke 23:33

The Skull: Greek kranion; the Aramaic term is *Golgotha* ([Matt 27:33](#); [Mark 15:22](#)). The location is uncertain, but it has traditionally been associated with the present Church of the Holy Sepulchre. A less likely location is Gordon's Calvary, a rock outcrop near the Garden Tomb. • they nailed him to the cross: Victims were often tied to the cross or nailed through the wrists and ankles to hasten death—here, the bodies had to be buried before sunset due to the approaching Sabbath.

Luke 23:34

by throwing dice (see [John 19:23-24](#)): The prisoner's possessions were treated as spoils of war and divided among the soldiers.

Luke 23:35

The crowd watched and the leaders scoffed (see [Ps 22:7-8](#)): [Psalm 22](#) speaks of David, a righteous sufferer, crying out to God for protection. Jesus, David's descendant, was the ultimate righteous sufferer who fulfilled [Ps 22](#).

Luke 23:36

Sour wine (cp. [Ps 69:21](#)) was a popular drink of the lower classes, especially among soldiers.

Luke 23:38

The sign confirmed that Jesus was crucified on the charge of claiming to be the King of the Jews (cp. [John 19:19-22](#)).

Luke 23:42

remember me when you come into your Kingdom: The criminal was perhaps thinking of the resurrection at the end of time, when Jesus would be raised up and vindicated by God.

Luke 23:43

Jesus corrected the man by assuring him that today he would be vindicated in God's presence (see also [2:11](#); [4:21](#); [5:26](#); [19:9](#)). • The word translated paradise comes from a Persian word that means "garden"; it was used in Jewish literature for the Garden of Eden and also for heaven, the place of eternal bliss for God's people (see [2 Cor 12:4](#); [Rev 2:7](#); cp. [Luke 16:22-23](#); [2 Cor 5:8](#)).

Luke 23:44

Darkness symbolizes sorrow as well as God's judgment ([Ps 23:4](#); [Isa 8:22](#); [9:1-2](#)).

Luke 23:45

the curtain in the sanctuary of the Temple: One curtain separated the Temple courtyard from the Holy Place, and another separated the Holy Place from the Most Holy Place. Luke does not say which was torn down the middle, but it was probably the latter—Jesus' death put an end to the sacrificial system of the Temple and opened a new and permanent way into the presence of God (see [Heb 10:19-20](#)).

Luke 23:46

Father, I entrust my spirit into your hands! See [Ps 31:5](#); [Ps 31](#) is another psalm about a righteous sufferer (see study note on Luke 23:35).

Luke 23:47

innocent (or *righteous*; cp. [Mark 15:39](#)): Cp. [Luke 23:14-15](#). The innocent and righteous servant of the Lord died as a sacrifice for the sins of his people ([Isa 53:11](#)).

Luke 23:48

went home in deep sorrow (literally *went home beating their breasts*): Beating the breast was a sign of sorrow and mourning.

Luke 23:50-51

Not all the religious leaders opposed Jesus—Joseph had opposed the actions of the council. • The location of Arimathea in Judea is uncertain; it might be Ramathaim (= Ramah), twenty miles (thirty-two kilometers) northwest of Jerusalem.

Luke 23:52

He went to Pilate and asked for Jesus' body: The Romans used crucifixion as a public warning against revolt, so they did not generally allow a victim to be buried. Instead, they left the body exposed or rotting on the cross. An exception was made in this case, probably because Pilate knew

that Jesus was innocent and because of Joseph's position of prestige on the Jewish high council.

Luke 23:53

The new tomb had probably been purchased by Joseph as a family tomb.

Luke 23:54

This was done late on Friday afternoon, the day of preparation: The Greek text does not explicitly refer to Friday, but simply to the day of preparation for the Sabbath of Passover week; the Sabbath began Friday evening. • as the Sabbath was about to begin: The body had to be buried quickly, because the Jews could not work during the Sabbath, which began at sunset.

Luke 23:55-56

The women took special note of the tomb's location because they would return with spices and ointments to anoint his body. The spices were to mask the stench of a rotting corpse. A body would be placed on a stone bench in the side of the tomb until the flesh decomposed. The bones would then be collected and placed in a small ossuary, or bone box, and placed on a shelf in the tomb. In this way, a tomb could be used for many family members over an extended period of time.

Luke 24:1

But very early on Sunday morning: The early church worshiped on the first day of the week (Sunday) instead of the seventh (Saturday, the Sabbath) because Jesus rose on a Sunday morning (cp. [Acts 20:7](#); [Rev 1:10](#)).

Luke 24:1-12

Women were the first to find the tomb empty and to hear the announcement of the resurrection. This is strong evidence for the historicity of the resurrection accounts. In first-century Judaism, women were not regarded as reliable witnesses, so the church would never have created stories in which women discovered the empty tomb.

Luke 24:2

The stone was probably a large round stone that was rolled down a track to cover the tomb's entrance.

Luke 24:4

two men suddenly appeared: Angels often appear as young men in Scripture ([Gen 18:2](#); [19:1](#), [10](#); [Josh 5:13](#); [Judg 13:6-11](#); [Heb 13:2](#)). Dazzling white robes symbolize purity and holiness ([Dan 10:5-6](#); [Acts 1:10](#); [Rev 4:4](#); [19:14](#)).

Luke 24:5-7

Jesus had told his followers many times that he would rise from the dead (see [9:22](#), [44](#); [17:25](#); [18:31-34](#)). Jesus' resurrection is a key tenet of the Christian faith (see [1 Cor 15:3-7](#), [12-57](#)).

Luke 24:7

Jesus rose on the third day, counting Friday as the first day and Sunday as the third.

Luke 24:9

His eleven disciples were the Twelve minus Judas.

Luke 24:10

Mary Magdalene and Joanna are mentioned in [8:2-3](#). Mary the mother of James is not the mother of James, the son of Zebedee (see [Matt 27:56](#)), but might be the mother of James, the son of Alphaeus ([Luke 6:15](#)).

Luke 24:12

Peter . . . ran to the tomb to look: John also accompanied Peter ([John 20:2-9](#)).

Luke 24:13

two of Jesus' followers: Jesus had many disciples in addition to the Twelve (see [10:1](#), [17](#)). Nothing else is known of Cleopas ([24:18](#)) or the other disciple (who may have been his wife). They were probably returning from celebrating the Passover in Jerusalem.

Luke 24:13–34

This account is Luke's unique contribution to the resurrection narratives. Jesus corrected these disciples' misunderstanding by showing from Scripture that it was necessary for the Messiah to suffer. He then opened their eyes to the truth of his resurrection.

Luke 24:16

God kept them from recognizing him: The Greek uses a passive construction (*they were kept from recognizing him*) known as a "divine passive," with God as the implied subject. God intentionally blinded their eyes until the moment of revelation, when Jesus broke bread with them ([24:30–31](#); cp. [2 Kgs 6:17](#)).

Luke 24:18

the only person in Jerusalem who hasn't heard about all the things: The Romans conducted crucifixions at major public crossroads to make an example of the victims and warn others against revolt. It was unthinkable to these disciples that a Passover pilgrim would not have heard of Jesus' crucifixion.

Luke 24:19

Jesus is often portrayed as a prophet in Luke's Gospel (see [7:16](#); cp. the description of Moses in [Acts 7:22](#)).

Luke 24:21

We had hoped he was the Messiah: Literally *we had hoped he was the one who would deliver Israel*. This

is a reference to the Messiah—the crucifixion had dashed their hopes.

Luke 24:22

an amazing report: See [24:10–11](#).

Luke 24:25–26

the prophets wrote . . . that the Messiah would have to suffer: The crucifixion did not negate Jesus' identity as the Messiah but confirmed it, because the death of the Messiah was predicted in Scripture. Jesus rebuked the two for not recognizing from Scripture that the Messiah had to suffer (see [Isa 50:4–9](#); [52:13–53:12](#); [Pss 2, 16, 22, 118](#); cp. [Luke 18:32](#); [20:17](#); [23:37](#); [Acts 2:25–28](#); [4:25–26](#)).

Luke 24:27

All the Scriptures, meaning all of the Old Testament, point forward to the coming of Jesus the Messiah and the salvation that he would bring.

Luke 24:29

they begged him, "Stay the night with us": Middle Eastern hospitality demanded that they offer food and lodging to this stranger ([Gen 18:3](#); [19:2](#); [Judg 19:5–9](#)).

Luke 24:30

As they sat down to eat: The meal is a symbol of the messianic banquet and of the salvation that God is accomplishing ([Isa 25:6–8](#); [Luke 14:1–24](#)). • Then he broke it and gave it to them: This action recalls the feeding of the 5,000 ([9:16](#)) and the institution of the Lord's Supper ([22:19](#)).

Luke 24:31

their eyes were opened: This is another example of the "divine passive" (see study note on 24:16); God opened their eyes at the breaking of the bread. • at that moment he disappeared! In his resurrected

and transformed body, Jesus had abilities not realized before the resurrection (see [24:36](#); [1 Cor 15:20-23](#), [35-57](#)).

Luke 24:34

Peter: This appearance to Simon Peter is not narrated in the Gospels, but Paul independently confirms it in [1 Cor 15:5](#).

Luke 24:39

ghosts don't have bodies, as you see that I do: In his resurrected state, Jesus was not an immaterial spirit, but had a real immortal and imperishable body. Believers will receive similar bodies at the final resurrection ([1 Cor 15:35-57](#)).

Luke 24:44

the law of Moses and the prophets and in the Psalms: Jesus referred to the three sections of the Hebrew Scriptures: the Law, the Prophets, and the Writings. The entire Old Testament points to God's salvation through Christ.

Luke 24:46

that the Messiah would suffer and die: See study note on 24:25-26.

Luke 24:47

The Old Testament was the universal proclamation of the Gospel to all the nations: See [Isa 42:6](#); [49:6](#); [Joel 2:28-32](#); [Amos 9:11-12](#); [Acts 2:17-21](#); [13:47](#); [15:16-18](#).

Luke 24:48

The primary role of the apostles in the book of Acts was to be witnesses to the fulfillment of Scripture in the life, death, and resurrection of Jesus (see [Acts 1:8](#)).

Luke 24:49

I am sending the promise of My Father: The Old Testament prophesied that God would pour out his Holy Spirit on all people ([Isaiah 32:15](#); [Jeremiah 31:33](#); [Ezekiel 36:26-27](#); [Joel 2:28-32](#)). This prophecy came true on the day of Pentecost ([Acts 2:14-21](#)).

Luke 24:50

Bethany: See study note on 19:29; see also [Acts 1:11-12](#); cp. [Zech 14:4](#).

Luke 24:50-53

Luke also narrates Jesus' ascension in [Acts 1:1-11](#). For Luke, Jesus' ascension confirmed his vindication, exaltation, and enthronement at God's right hand as Messiah and Lord ([Acts 2:24-36](#)). From his position of glory and authority in heaven, Jesus guides and directs his church.

Luke 24:51

Cp. [2 Kgs 2:11](#). Jesus' ascension was his exaltation to a position of authority over all creation (see [Acts 2:32-36](#); [5:31](#); [Eph 1:19-23](#); [Phil 2:9-11](#); [Heb 1:13](#)).

Luke 24:53

The Temple was a place of worship as well as of sacrifice. The apostles continued in their Jewish manner of worship because their goal was not to create a new religion but to announce the fulfillment of Scripture's promises of salvation through Jesus the Messiah.